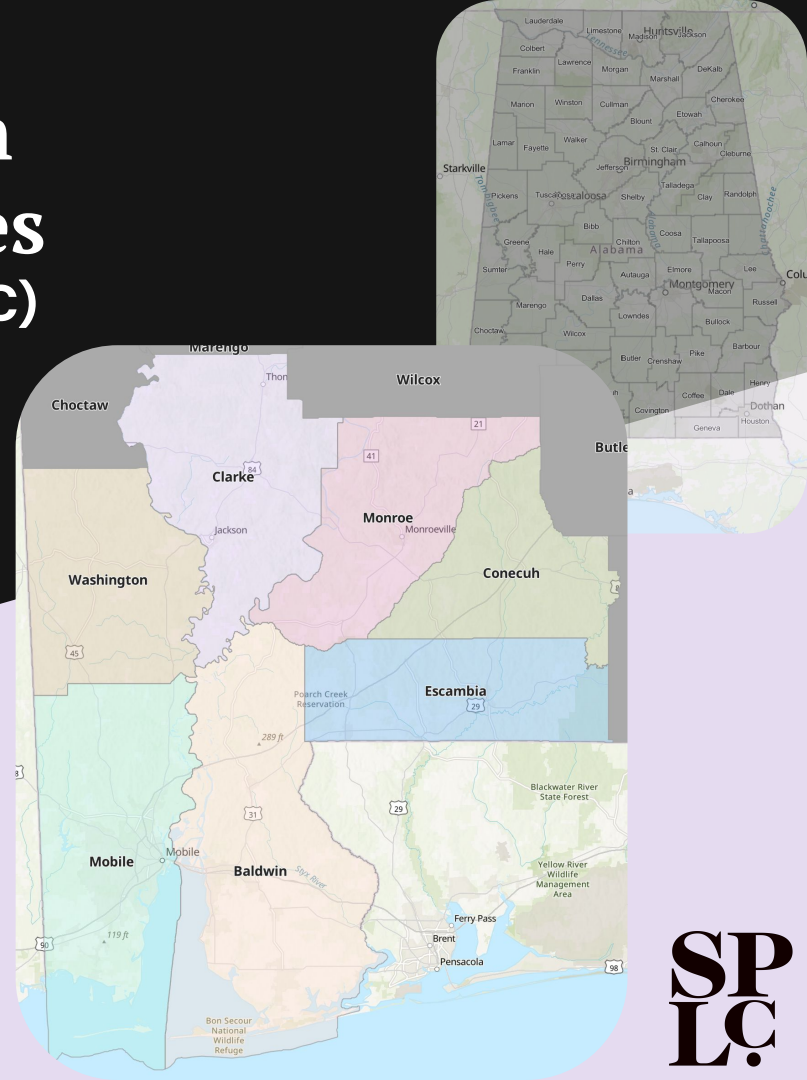


Voting & Civic Participation Alabama Gulf Coast Counties

Client: Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC)

College of Information, University of Maryland
iConsultancy Capstone Section 105
Spring 2026



Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC)

Fred McBride

SPLC Senior Supervising Data and Research Analyst | Legal Management

Zach Mahafza

SPLC Senior Research Analyst | Legal Management

Jack Slate

SPLC Alabama State Office



Founded 1971 in Montgomery, Alabama

Who they are: A nonprofit civil rights law and research organization

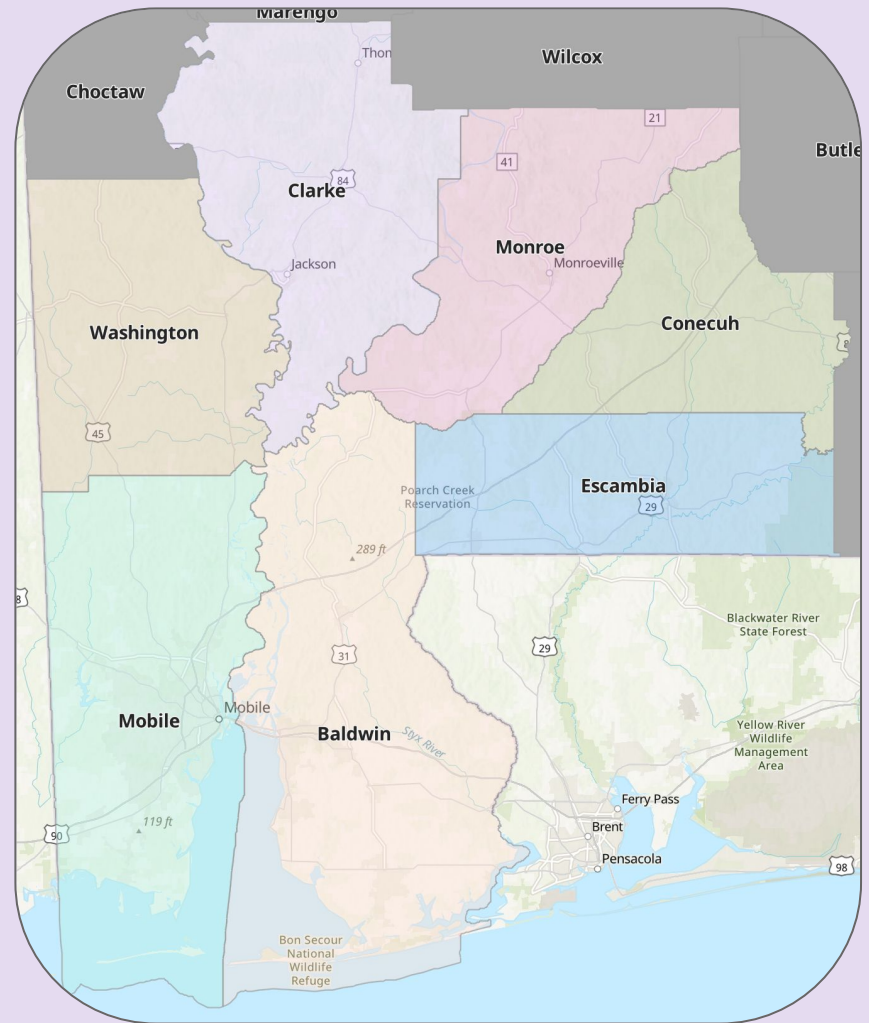
- Litigation, policy analysis, data-driven research, and public education—focused on systemic inequities and barriers affecting marginalized communities

What they asked for: Descriptive, historical analysis of civic participation and voting access across the Alabama Gulf Coast

- Voter turnout patterns among Black and Latine voters, physical access to polling locations, and access-related barriers across the region

Our Focus

We have worked throughout the semester in separate teams to build a unified project that describes several components of voting and civic participation across the Gulf Coast Region of Alabama



Gulf Coast Region Summary Card

County	Population	Citizens 18+	% Black	% Latine	Median HH Income
Mobile	412,339	311,162	36%	4%	\$60,379
Baldwin	261,608	203,317	8%	6%	\$82,501
Clarke	22,543	17,552	45%	1%	\$49,249
Conecuh	11,275	8,970	45%	1%	\$41,327
Escambia	36,629	28,243	29%	2%	\$48,225
Monroe	19,388	15,267	42%	0%	\$42,292
Washington	15,143	12,083	24%	1%	\$61,042
Alabama	5,157,699	3,901,455	25%	6%	\$66,659
United States	340,110,980	245,275,124	12%	20%	\$81,604

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 2024 1-year estimates (Mobile, Baldwin) and 2019–2023 5-year estimates (Clarke, Conecuh, Escambia, Monroe, Washington). Voting-eligible citizens reflect ACS Table B29001. Retrieved from [Census Reporter, censusreporter.org](https://censusreporter.org)

Our Goal

Our project's goal is to understand what impacts civic participation in the Alabama Gulf Coast Counties

Using insights from our work this semester, we have identified some key factors that influence civic participation and propose targeted recommendations for how the SPLC can respond to them

Project Team 1: Regional Voting Data Integration & Governance (GC-DIG)

- ❑ *Carter Kinch, Cidel Tetteh, Lin Han, Colin Sullivan, John Valencia*

Project Team 2: Voter Turnout & Participation Trends (GC-VOTE)

- ❑ *Afreen Ahmed, Nana Akuffo, Ryan Yu, Frank Okonsky, Nivitha Paranthaman, Manasvi Hosahalli*

Project Team 3: Polling Place Access & Distance Analysis (GC-PAD)

- ❑ *Casey Pham, Ana Salazar, Keon Marandy, Khadija Wane, Nhi Pham*

Project Team 4: Transportation Barriers to Civic Participation (GC-TRAC)

- ❑ *Andy Nguyen, Ayush Jain, Amisiyas Seyoum, Basirat Gbadegesin, Robert Tzou*

Project Team 5: ADA Accessibility & Compliance at Polling Locations (GC-AACS)

- ❑ *Sirisha Koirala, Sungjae Pae, Prince Osei, Elizabeth Jarvio-Barahona, Kediel Lam*

Project Team 6: Broadband & Digital Access for Civic Participation (GC-BAND)

- ❑ *Crystal Samoya, Asia Robillard-Hill, Lyndsey Bakal, Amir Pourmand, Garrett Bugg*

Project Team 7: Composite Civic Participation Risk Index (GC-CPRI)

- ❑ *Nathan Maldonado, Moiz Uddin, Akhil Ramesh, Talha Sohail, Elijah Lambros*

Project Team 8: Data Visualization & Dashboard Design (GC-VIZ)

- ❑ *Jin Peng, Alexander Peterson, Hana Hazem Elbarony, Mohammad Shahid, Noah Lehrfeld, Sera Belasco*

Project Team 9: Community Context & Personas (GC-CCP)

- ❑ *Bruktawit Mekonnen, Ryan Birmingham, Ayanna Sterling, Sue Chen, Ifa Bato*

Project Team 10: Policy & Organizational Translation (GC-PORT)

- ❑ *Sirak Abraham, Siddhi Kacholia, Margaret Nowell, Andrew Lu*

Project Team 11: Civic Participation Process & Access Design (GC-CPAD)

- ❑ *Janet Dabu, Mei Pierson, Ismail Touray, Daniel Chavez Celis*

Data Foundation

Redistricting
Data Hub



What Data Made This Project Possible

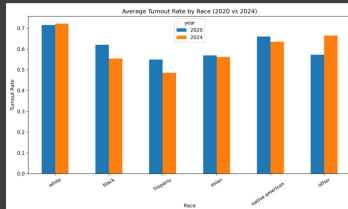
- **Voter Registration & Turnout:** AL Secretary of State, 2020 and 2024; Redistricting Hub
- **Demographics:** U.S. Census Bureau ACS 5-Year Estimates
- **Geospatial/GIS:** Polling locations, precinct boundaries, road networks
- **Infrastructure:** FCC broadband maps, transit availability data

Team 1 also documented data gaps, boundary changes, and source limitations

The Divergence Begins in the Data

-6.6pts

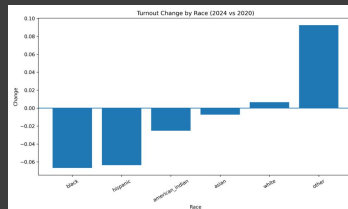
Average drop in Black voter turnout, 2020–2024, across all seven counties



+0.7pts

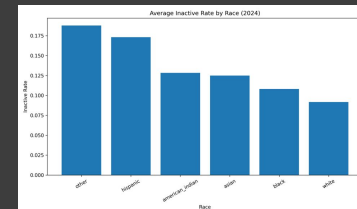
Average change in white voter turnout, same period

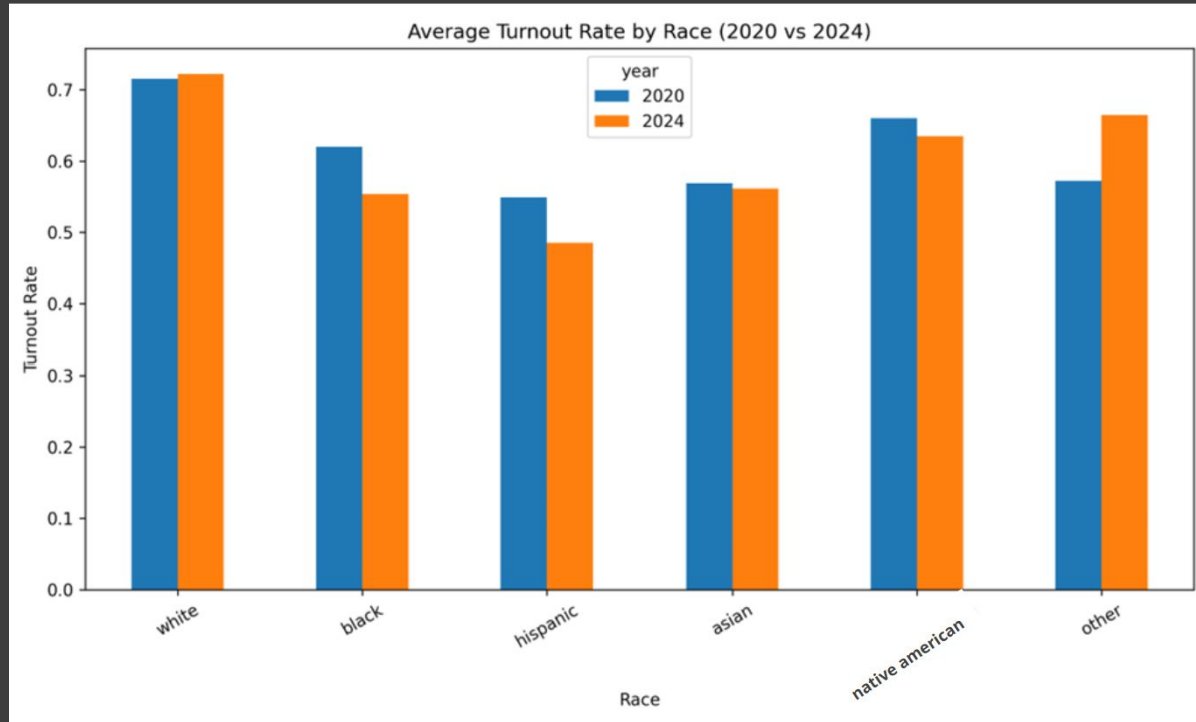
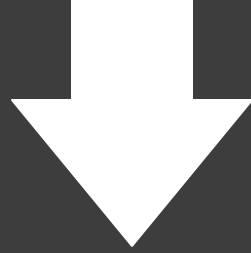
This divergence appeared in every single county in the region



17.3%

Latine registered voters carry the highest inactive registration rate of any racial group



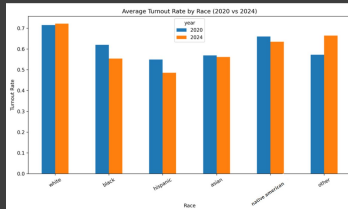


Average voter turnout rates by race for 2020 and 2024 based on state election data. Black and Latine turnout decreased from 2020 to 2024, while white turnout slightly increased.

The Divergence Begins in the Data

-6.6pts

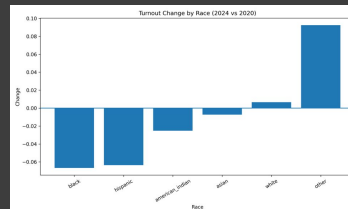
Average drop in Black voter turnout, 2020–2024, across all seven counties



+0.7pts

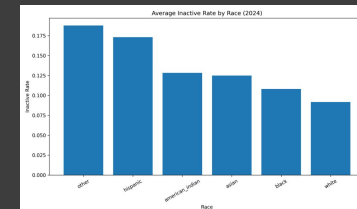
Average change in white voter turnout, same period

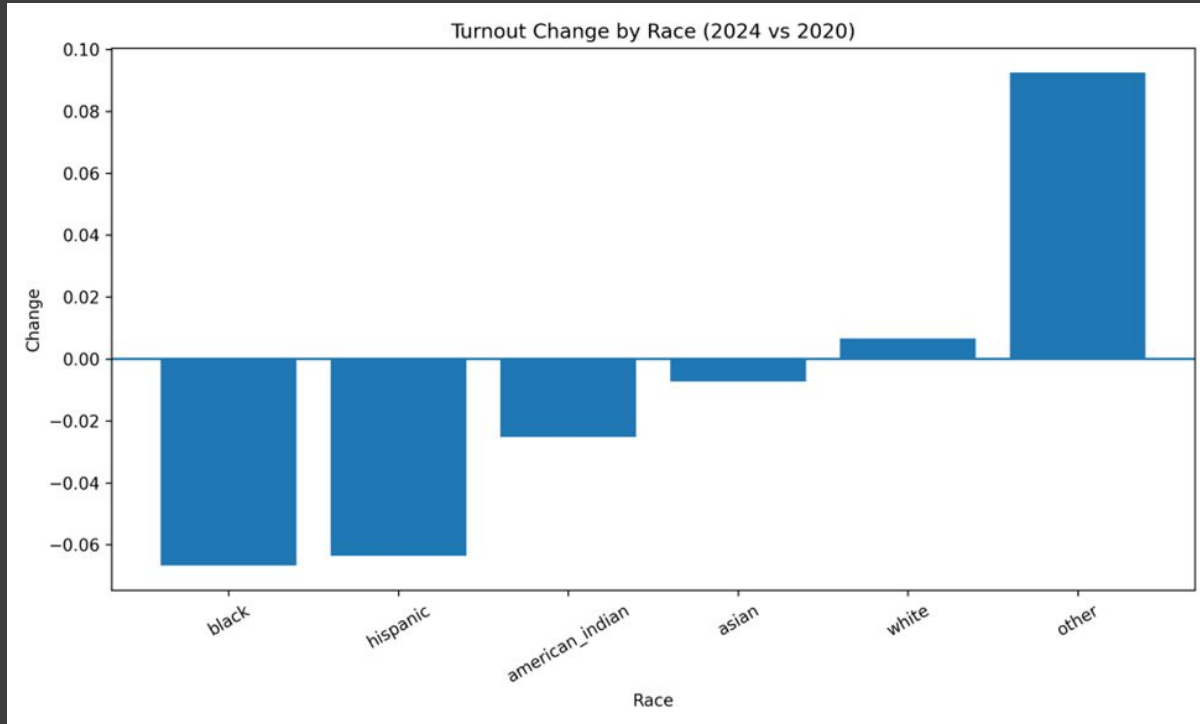
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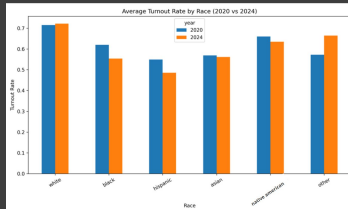


Change in voter turnout rates by race between 2020 and 2024. Black and Latine voters show the largest turnout decline, while white and other groups show small increases.

The Divergence Begins in the Data

-6.6pts

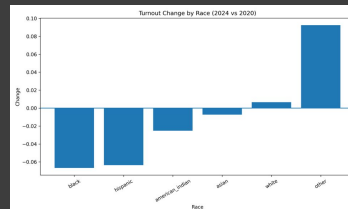
Average drop in Black voter turnout, 2020–2024, across all seven counties



+0.7pts

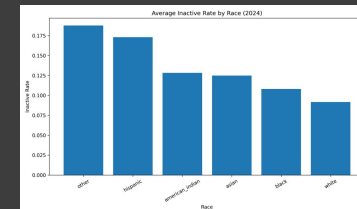
Average change in white voter turnout, same period

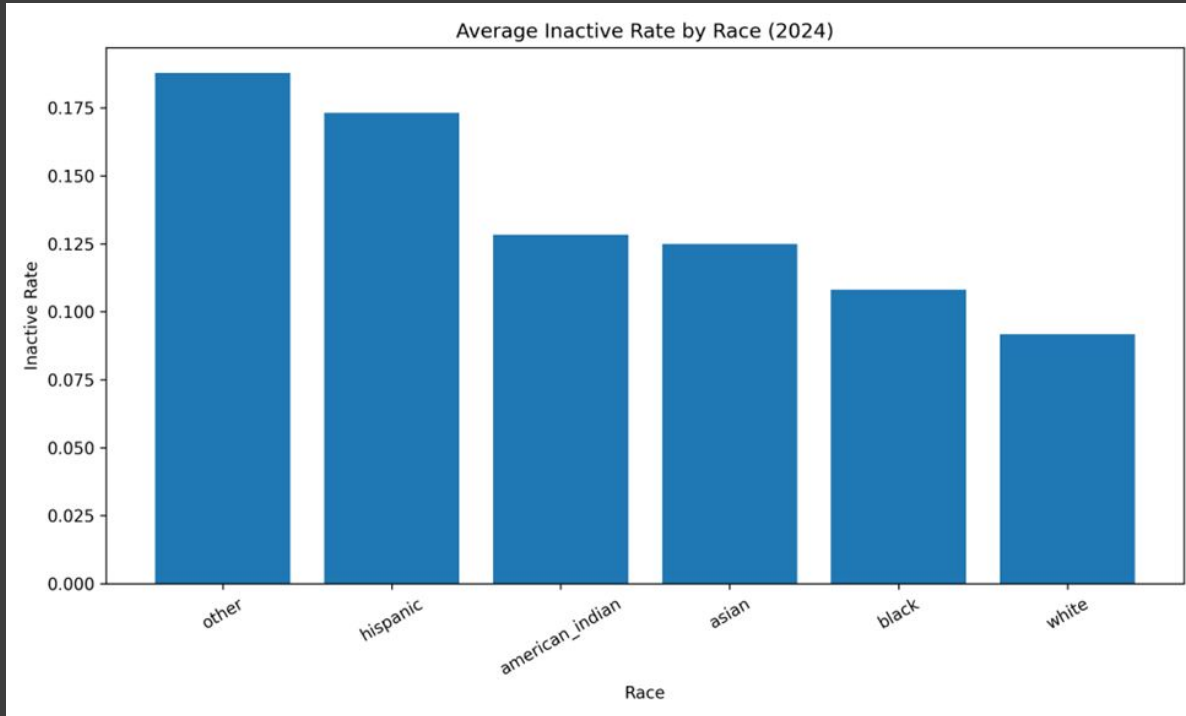
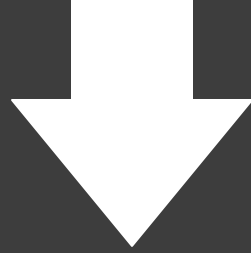
This divergence appeared in every single county in the region



17.3%

Latine registered voters carry the highest inactive registration rate of any racial group





Average inactive voter registration rates by race in 2024. Other and Latine voters have the highest inactive rates, and all minority groups are higher than white voters.

The People Behind the Data

Transportation, safety concerns, confusion over rights and policies, and polling location were some of the most commonly cited barriers to voting

To explore the community members' lived experiences with these barriers, Team 9 conducted secondary research to develop community personas representing voters in the Gulf Coast region—grounded in demographic data and research on barriers

Jay Hawk

GC-CCP: Persona 1



Age: 22 **Gender:** Male
Race: African American
Location: Mobile County
Job: Early Employment

Goals

- Learn how voting effects his future
- Live up to parents legacy

☆ Recent graduate from University of Alabama

Voting habits

- Gets information from parents
- Only votes during presidential elections

Motivations

- Parents participated in civil rights movement
- Wants to be more independent

He grew up learning about the civil rights movement. Both of his parents and grandparents were part of the civil rights era and understood the struggles during that time period. They would always tell him about these struggles and remind him to vote. However, he feels like the politics nowadays feel overwhelming and trying to navigate around the voting world and figure out who he believes in.

Mia Rodriguez

GC-CCP: Persona 2



Age: 62 **Gender:** Female
Race: Latina
Location: Baldwin County
Job: Unemployed

Goals

- Be a active US citizen
- Support her daughter's family

☆ Immigrated in 2010
☆ Citizenship in 2019
☆ Lives with daughter's family

Voting habits

- Depends on daughter's family on transportation
- aware of voting in the US but unsure how to vote
- Relies on her daughter and church/communities for reliable information

Motivations

- Better schools for grandchildren
- Opportunities for older Latin generations to immigrate to the USA
- Improving the US naturalization process
- Trustworthy communication for community members

She is in her early 60s, originally from Mexico, and lives with her daughter's family in Baldwin County. When she immigrated from Mexico to the United States, she did not know much English, how the government worked, or what day to day life was like. Her days revolve around helping her daughter's family through cooking meals, picking up her grandkids from school, helping with homework, and providing stability at home. She attends Mass on the weekend at Foley Hispanic SDA Church and feels connected to the community through church. She wants to be an active citizen but finds sourcing information to be difficult. When it comes to voting, she won't participate unless she fully grasps what she is voting for.



Age: 48 **Gender:** Female
Race: African American
Location: Mobile County
Job: Administrative Assistant at local healthcare facility

Goals

- Support efforts that improve education
- Keep home life stable
- Stay informed on local issues

☆ PTA mom at WP Davidson High School
 ☆ Activate at Little Flower Catholic Church

Voting habits

Communication

- [Mobile County Website](#)
- [Mobile County Facebook](#)

Schedule

- Busy schedule with kids at two different schools
- Demanding job
- Volunteers on the weekends
- Attends PTA meetings

Motivations

- Ensure opportunities and education for her children and the children in the community
- neighborhood safety

She is a 48 year old African American woman in Mobile County who participates in her community through faith and participation in WP Davidson High School's PTA. She works full-time at the local health care facility and also supports her kids' school activities. Neighbors, school parents, and church parents see her as a trusted voice in the community and as someone who organizes food drives and other community events. She votes occasionally but finds it difficult to make time to vote and to learn information about who to vote for.



Age: 35 **Gender:** Male
Race: African American
Location: Conecuh County
Job: Unemployed

Goals

- Regain their right to vote
- Fully rejoin society and rebuild his life
- Fair treatment from government bodies

☆ was incarcerated for non violent felony

Voting habits

- Does not currently vote due to an unclear procedure for becoming eligible to vote again
- Relies on his community organizations to get information. This mainly includes information via word of mouth and community groups

Motivations

- Wants to feel included in their community and wants to make an impact on what they believe in
- Wants to grow as a person after being incarcerated

He is a 35 year old man who convicted of theft at the age of 30. As a result, he lost many of his civil rights, including the right to vote. After completing his sentence and returning to his community, he now wants regain his rights. He feels that society judges him for the actions of his past. To regain a sense of self and grow, he feels that regaining his right to vote is a step in the right direction. With how things are, he is currently struggling with the current system to figure out how to get his rights back.

The Picture That Emerged

Voter Turnout: Who Shows Up, and Who Doesn't

Black and Latine voters are underrepresented in ballots cast relative to their share of the voter-eligible population—and the gap varies significantly by county

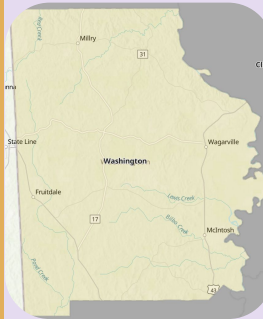


Escambia County: lowest rate of Black eligible voters casting ballots in the region

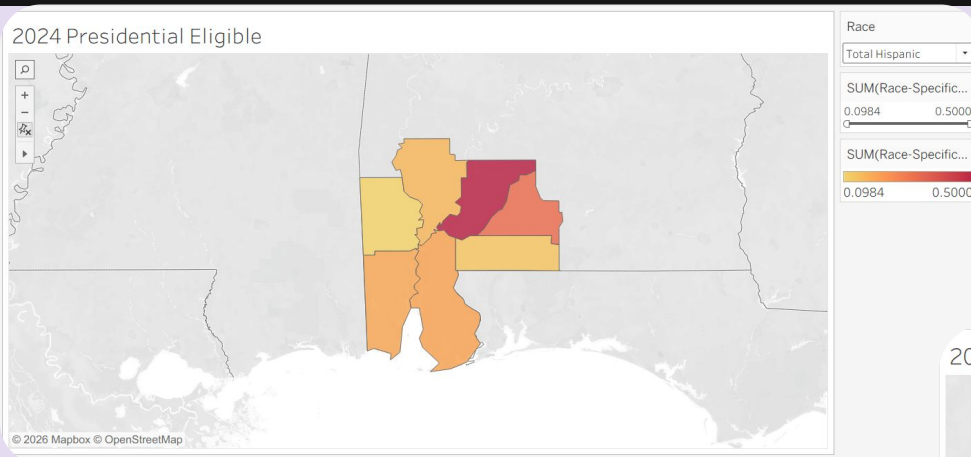
Baldwin County: largest gap between eligible and ballots cast for Black and Latine voters



Washington County: lowest Latine ballot-casting rate relative to eligible population

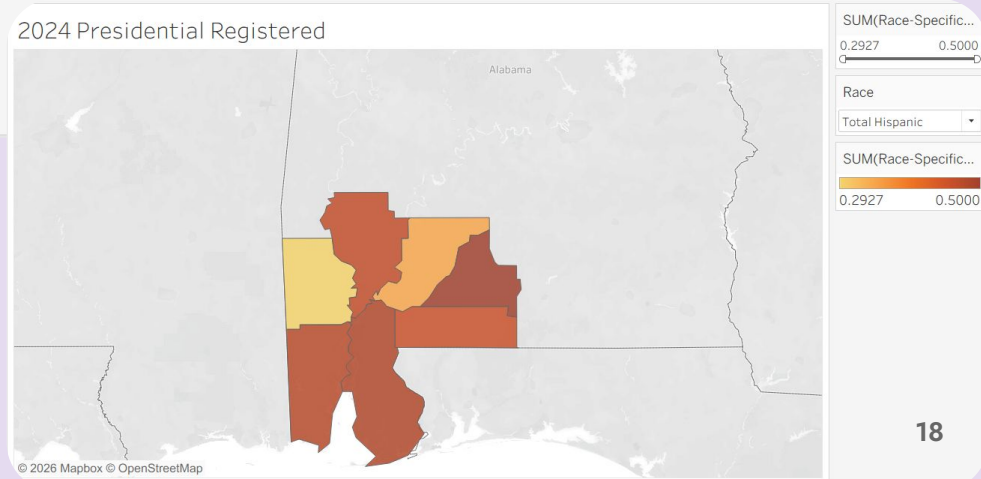


Eligibility vs. Registration of Latine Voters

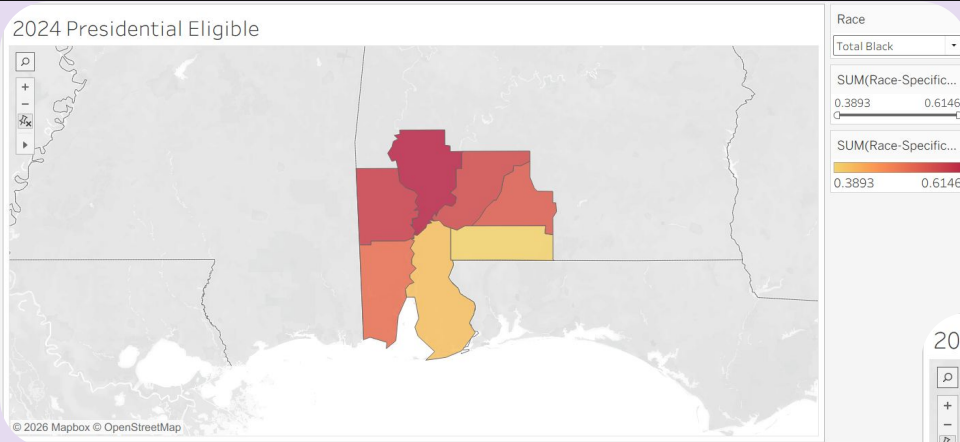


Proportion of eligible Latine voters that actually cast ballots in the 2024 Presidential and Vice Presidential Election. Washington county has the lowest proportion of 0.0984

Proportion of registered Latine voters that actually cast ballots in the 2024 Presidential and Vice Presidential Election

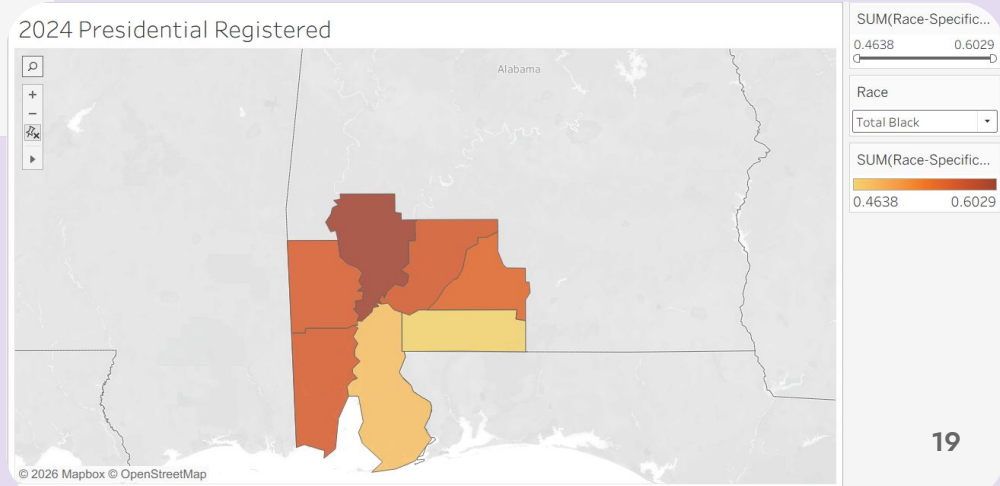


Eligibility vs Registration of Black Voters



Proportion of eligible Black voters that actually cast ballots in the 2024 Presidential and Vice Presidential Election

Proportion of registered Black voters that actually cast ballots in the 2024 Presidential and Vice Presidential Election



The Gap in 2024: Every County, Every Direction

County	White Turnout	Black Turnout	Gap
Baldwin	66.0%	44.0%	-22.0 pts
Escambia	61.7%	42.7%	-19.0 pts
Monroe	71.0%	52.3%	-18.7 pts
Clarke	73.6%	55.7%	-17.9 pts
Conecuh	66.2%	50.4%	-15.8 pts
Washington	67.6%	52.2%	-15.4 pts
Mobile	64.0%	51.2%	-12.8 pts
Alabama	65%	51%	-14 pts
United States	70.5%	59.6%	-10.9 pts

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 2024 1-year estimates (Mobile, Baldwin) and 2019–2023 5-year estimates (Clarke, Conecuh, Escambia, Monroe, Washington). Voting-eligible citizens reflect ACS Table B29001. Retrieved from censusreporter.org/AL Secretary of State

Broadband Access: The Barrier You Cannot See

Counties with weaker economic conditions have significantly more limited broadband access—particularly at speeds sufficient to use online civic tools

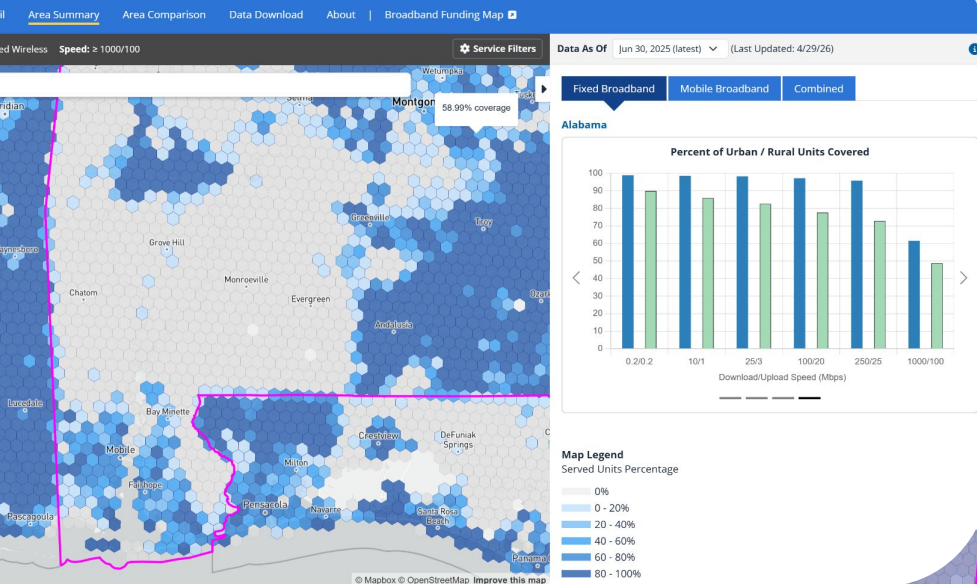
Most counties had only 5% of devices being able to access the highest available internet testing speed

Only 2 of 7 counties have meaningful high-speed broadband access

- ❑ **Baldwin** and **Mobile** had over 50% of their devices being able to do so, showing a divide

What absence or limited broadband access affects:

- ❑ Online voter registration
- ❑ Polling location lookup
- ❑ Absentee ballot requests
- ❑ Election information access

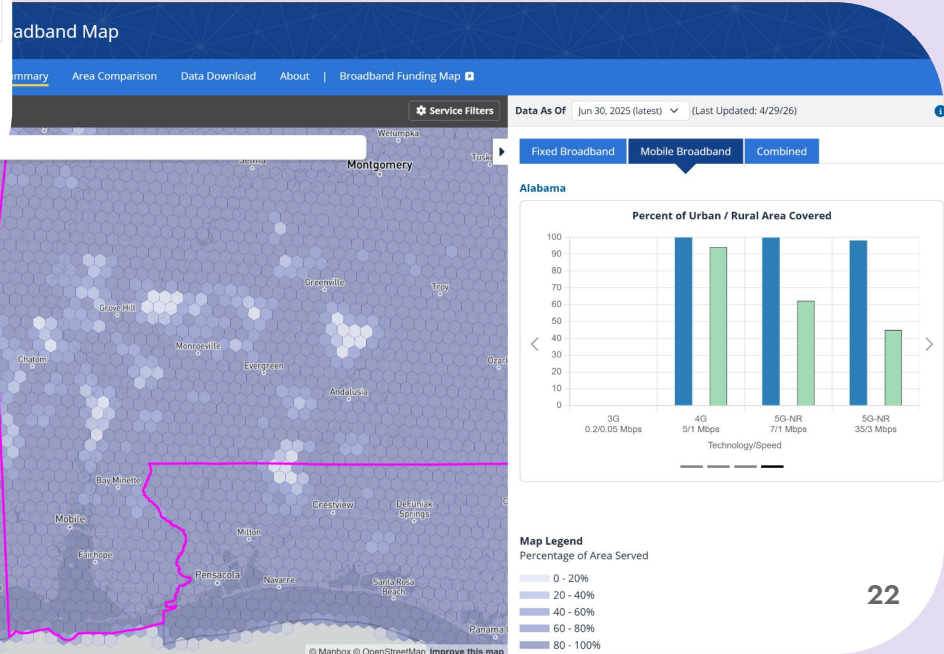


Fixed vs. Mobile Broadband in Gulf Coast Region

Fixed broadband is a wired connection to a home—cable, fiber, or DSL

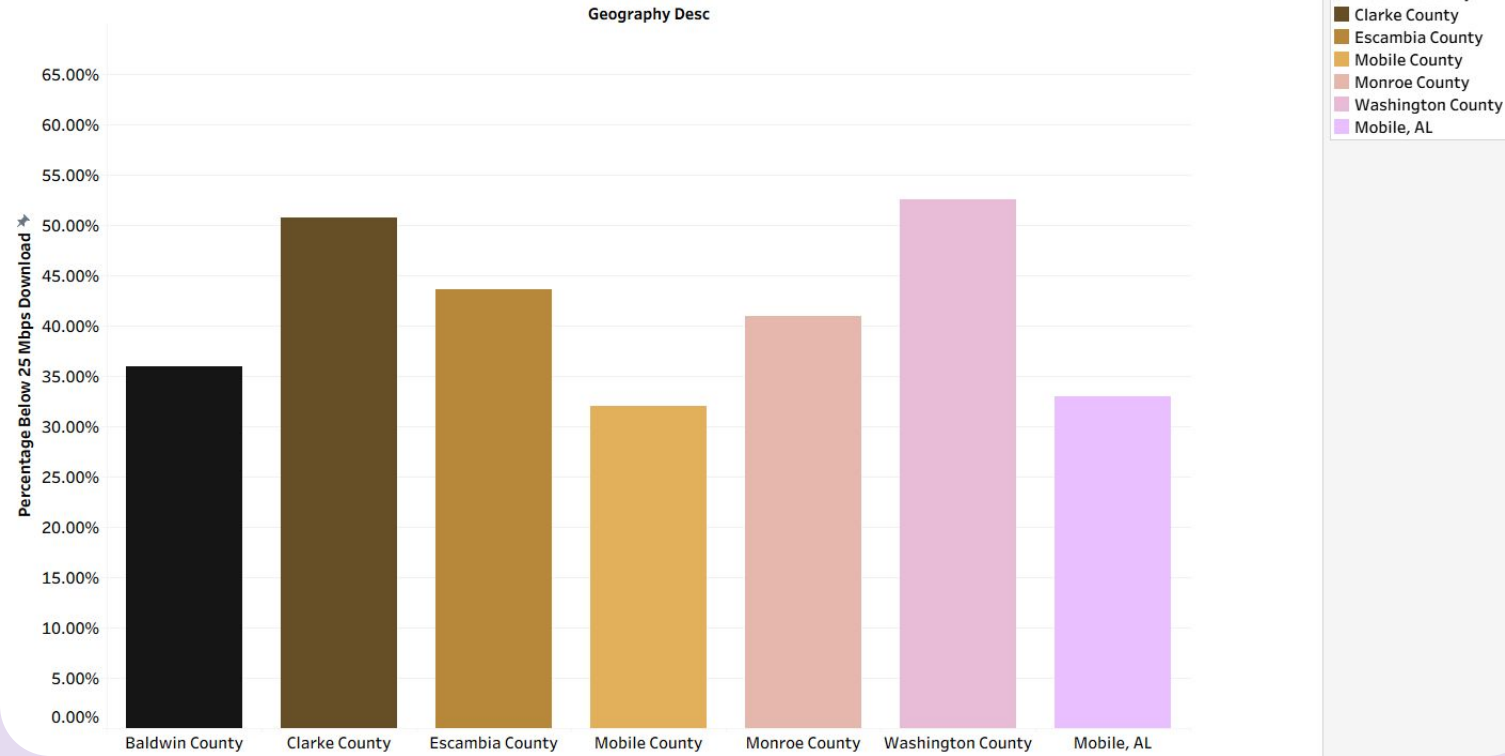
Mobile broadband runs over cellular networks

- **Fixed** is what matters for consistent civic participation
- **Mobile coverage** looks good on maps but is often slow, unreliable, or capped in rural areas—making tasks like voter registration or polling place lookup functionally unavailable



Broadband Access

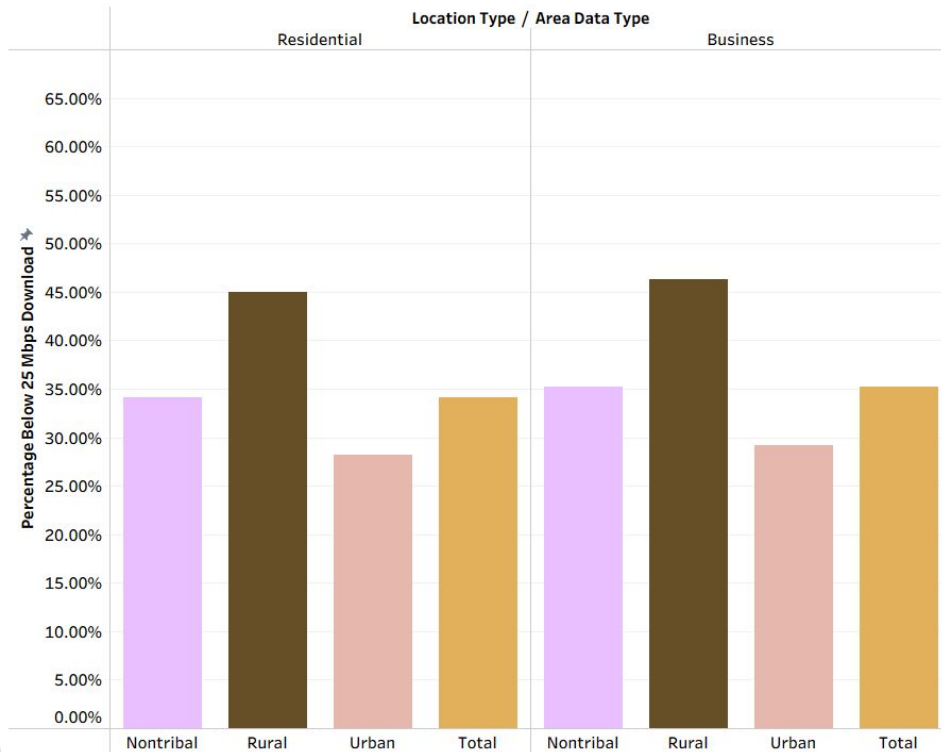
Alabama Overview



Counties with *weaker economic conditions* have significantly more limited broadband

Broadband Access

Baldwin County Users Below FCC Recommendation



Area Data Type

- Nontribal
- Rural
- Urban
- Total

Counties with *weaker economic conditions* have significantly more limited broadband

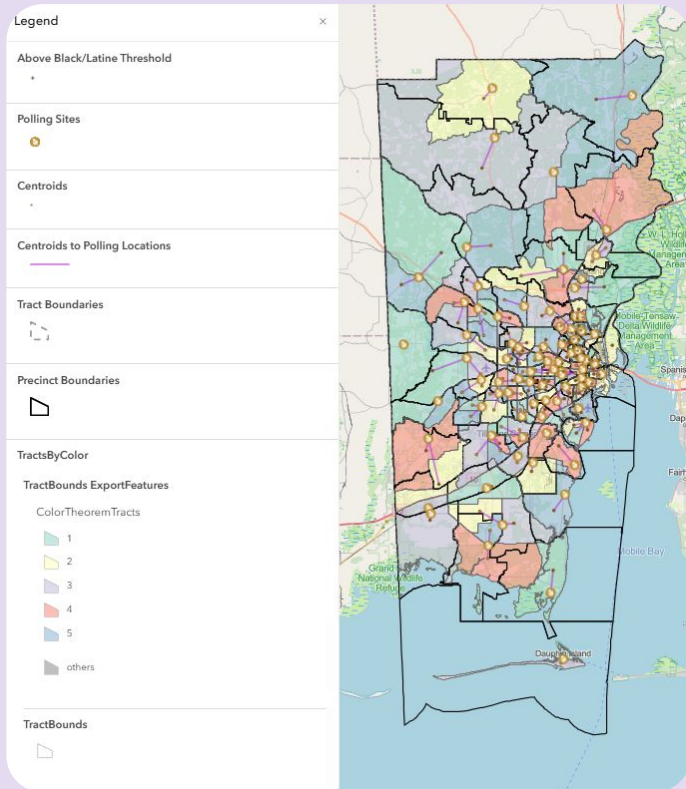
Polling Place Access: What the Distance Data Actually Shows

Team 3 conducted a tract-level spatial analysis of drive time from community population centers to assigned polling places in Mobile County, 2020—using ArcGIS Network Analyst to model realistic road-network driving time

What they found was *unexpected*

And it matters that you hear it precisely

Drive Time Was *Not* the Mechanism of Inequity Here



Census tracts with higher Black and Latine population shares *did not* have longer modeled driving times to assigned polling places

The relationship ran the *opposite direction*—higher Black/Latine population share was associated with shorter drive times

Why: Mobile County's geography

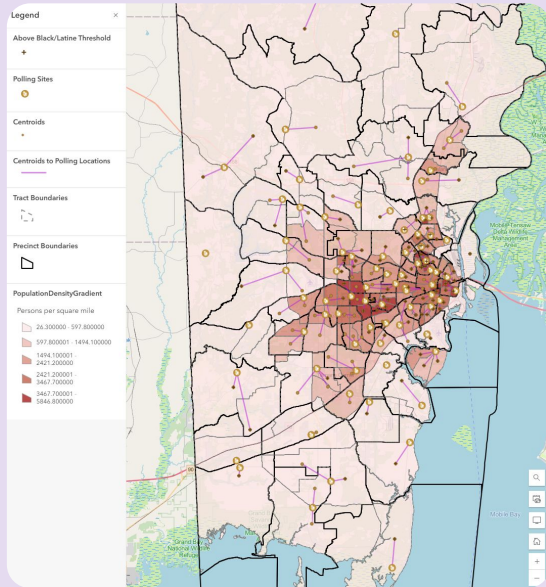
- ❑ Higher Black and Latine populations are concentrated in more urban, denser areas where precincts are smaller and polling places are closer

What this means for SPLC

- ❑ Drive time is not the barrier here. This analysis tells you where not to look, so you can focus on where to look

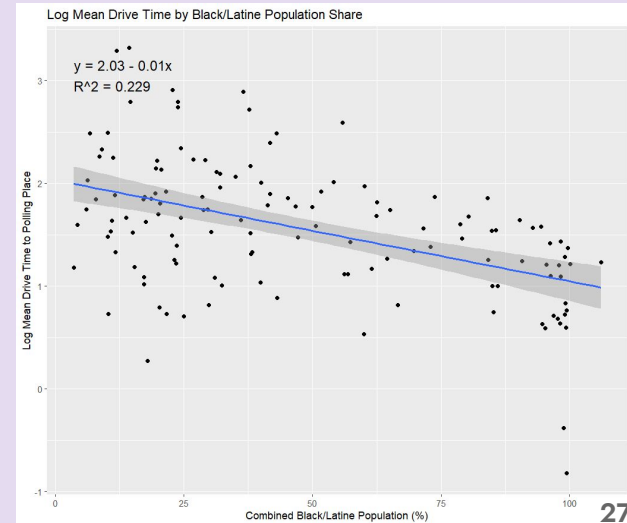
An overview of the Mobile County ArcGIS map, illustrating precincts (dark black lines), tracts (colored polygons), polling places (yellow hand holding paper icon), tract centroids (gold/dark yellow dots), and lines (purple) connecting centroids to their corresponding polling place. A "+" symbol has been overlaid on top of centroids that fell at or above the county average Black/Latine population percent.

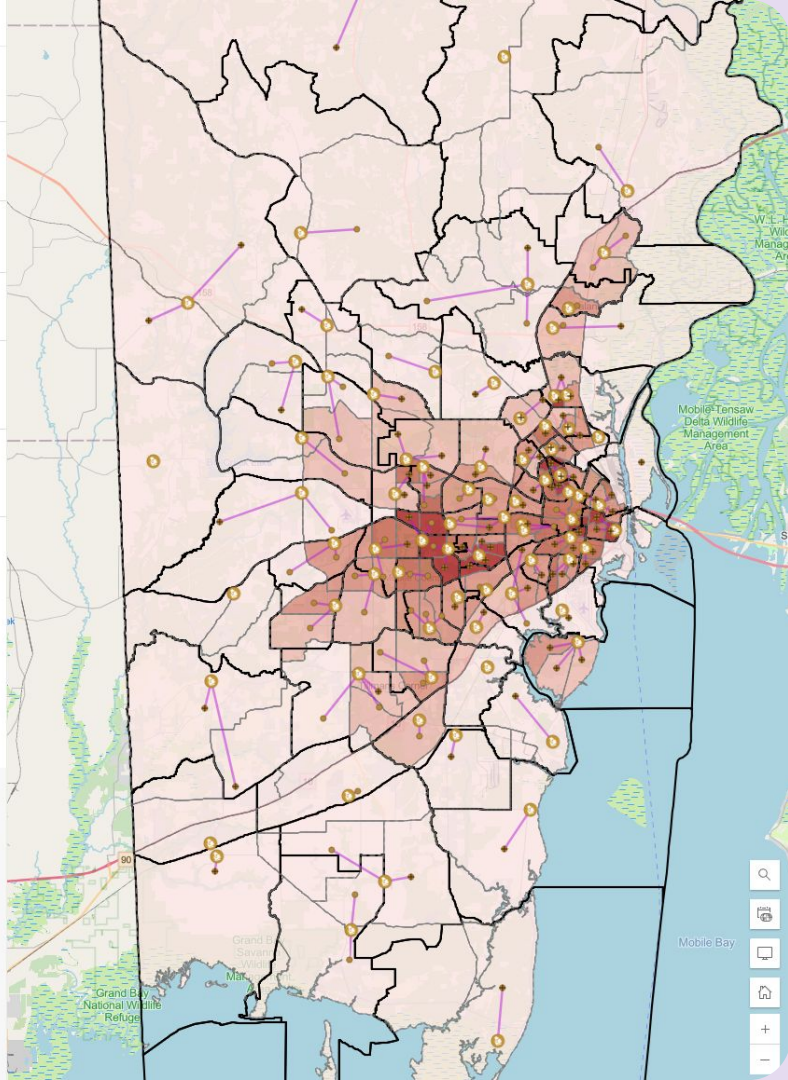
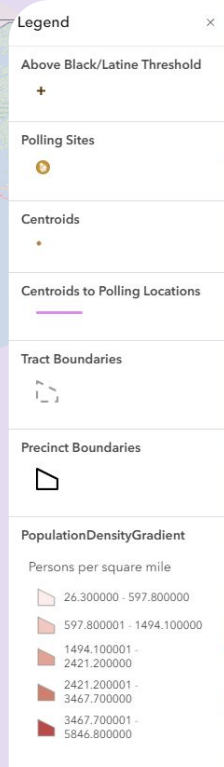
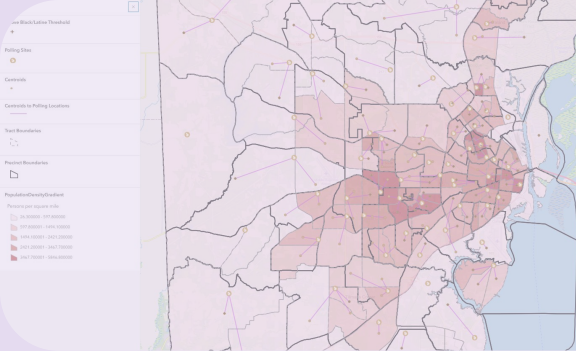
Urban Regions & Scatterplot Analysis



ArcGIS map overlaid with one of the supplemental visualization layers, **population density**, which is used to propose a potential explanation for the results of our statistical analysis (note that many of the population centroids with the "+" marker fall in these urban regions)

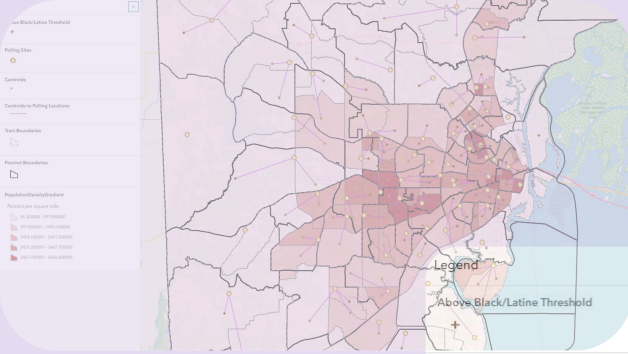
RStudio scatterplot showing combined Black/Latine population percentage vs. log transformed mean drive time, **demonstrating the negative relationship that appeared throughout our analysis**





Mobile County Urban Map

Mobile County Urban Map Black Population Density



Polling Sites



Centroids



Centroids to Polling Locations



Tract Boundaries



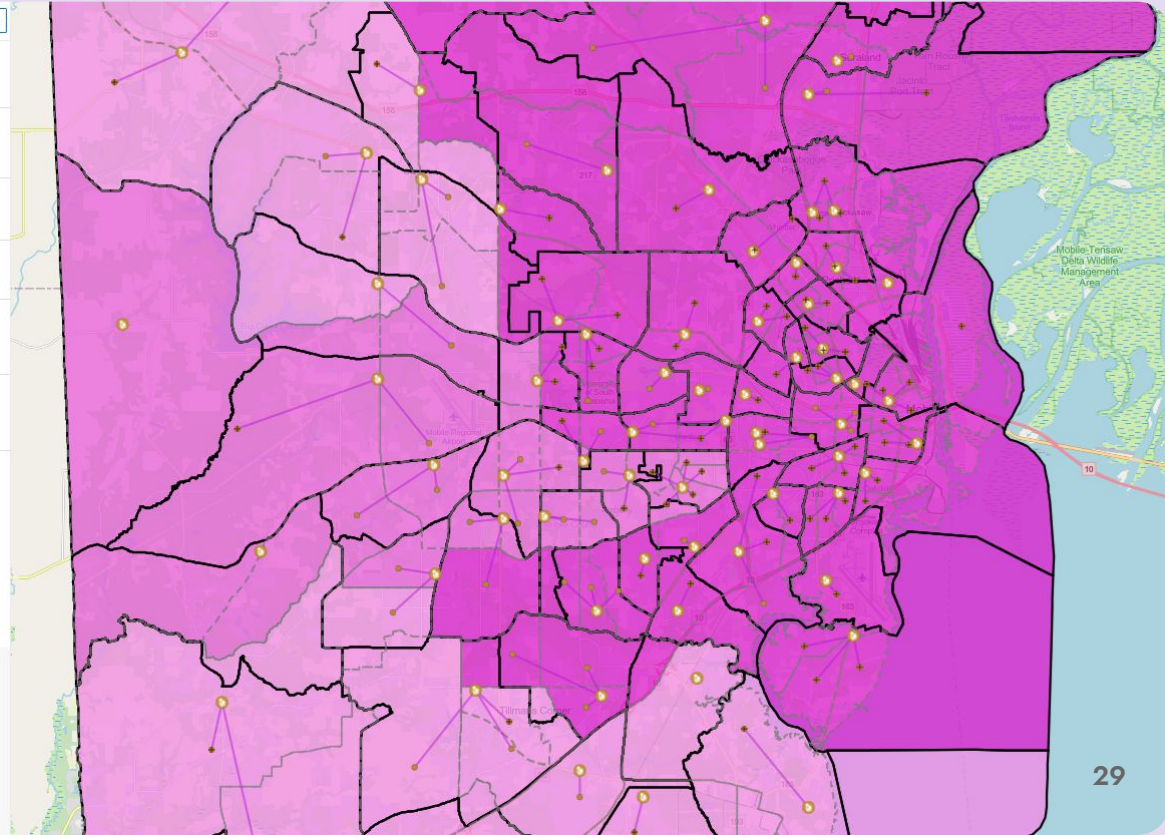
Precinct Boundaries



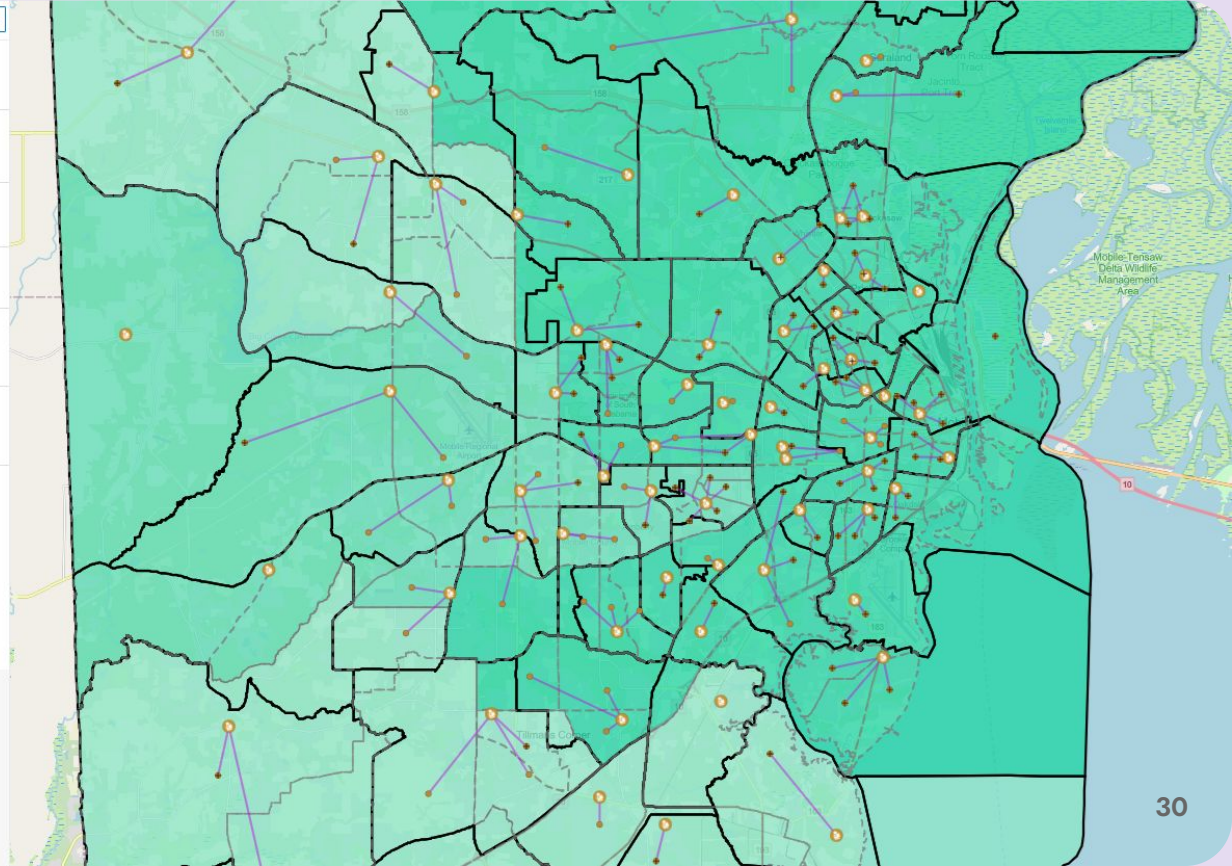
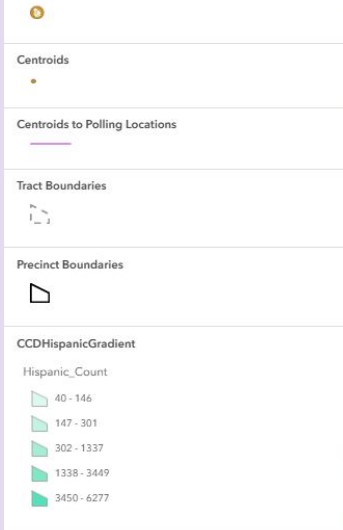
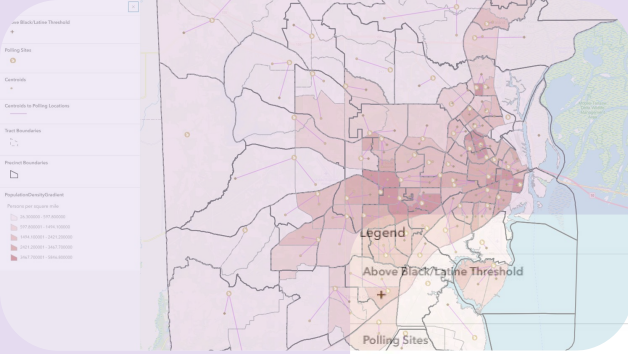
CCDBlackGradient

Black_Count

- 539
- 540 - 1585
- 1586 - 4465
- 4466 - 21765
- 21766 - 109200



Mobile County Urban Map Latine Population Density



Transportation Barriers: Getting There Is the Problem

Focusing on Mobile and Baldwin Counties, we found that *vehicle access is uneven*

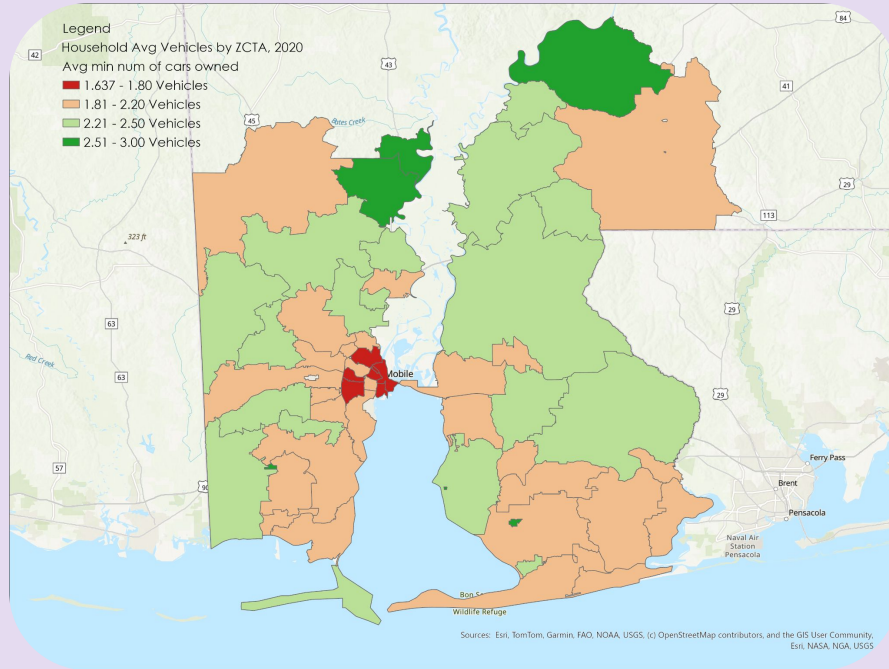
Some zip codes show persistently low household vehicle ownership in both 2020 and 2024 – ***the gap did not close***

The largest transportation gaps cluster in zip codes farthest from city centers—where transit coverage is also thinnest

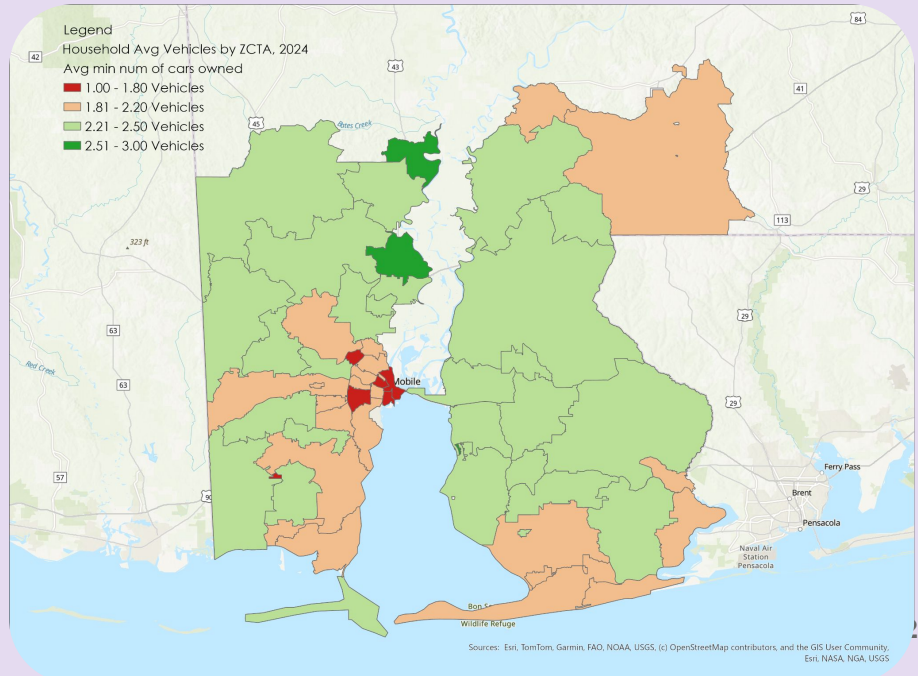
On Election Day, a meaningful number of Mobile County polling locations are not served by bus routes at all

2020 & 2024 Transportation Access

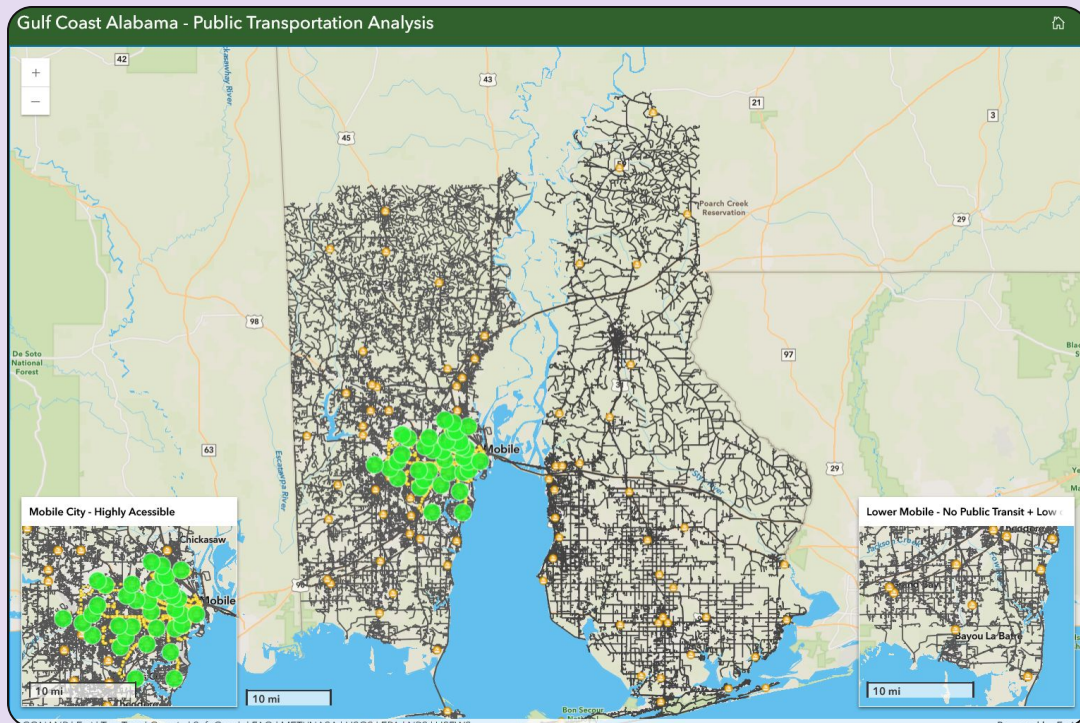
[Live Link to ArcGIS - 2020](#)



[Live Link to ArcGIS - 2024](#)



Public Transportation Analysis: Bus Routes



Within Mobile County, active bus routes are localized exclusively within **Mobile City**.

49.31%

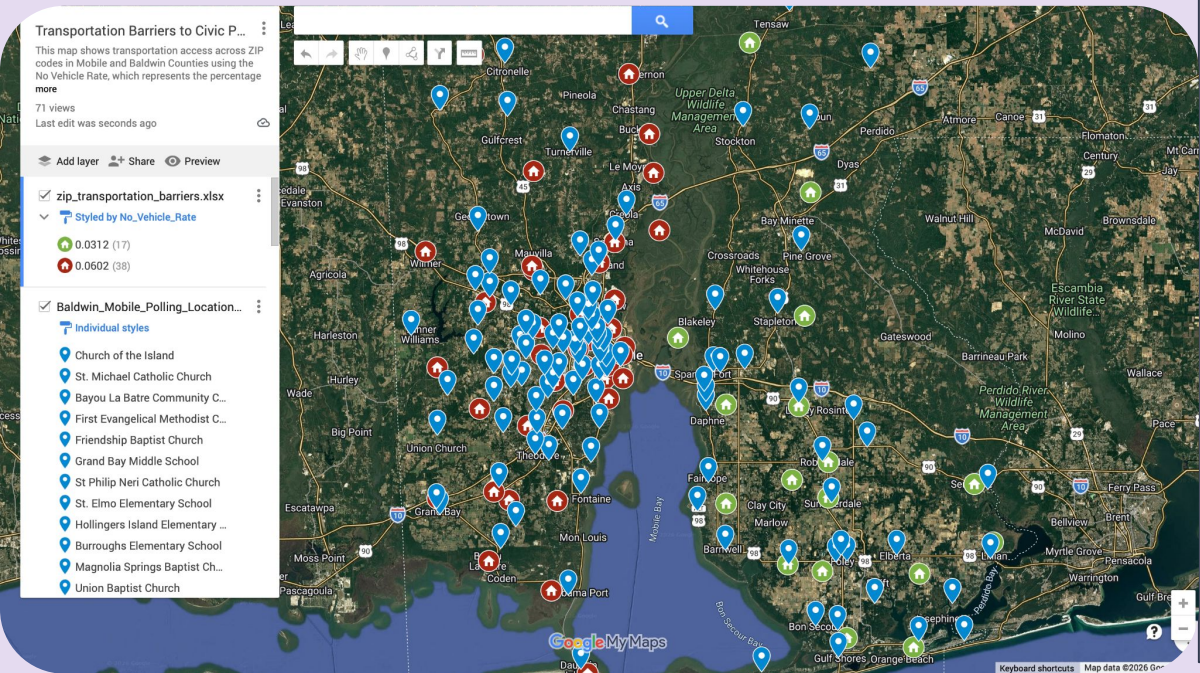
of polling locations (36 of 73) are accessible within a 30-minute walk of a bus station.

Map Legend

- Accessible via Bus
- Inaccessible via Bus

[Live ArcGIS Interactive Map](#)

Transportation Access Across Zip Codes



The map shows transportation accessibility across ZIP codes in Mobile County and Baldwin County using the No Vehicle Rate.

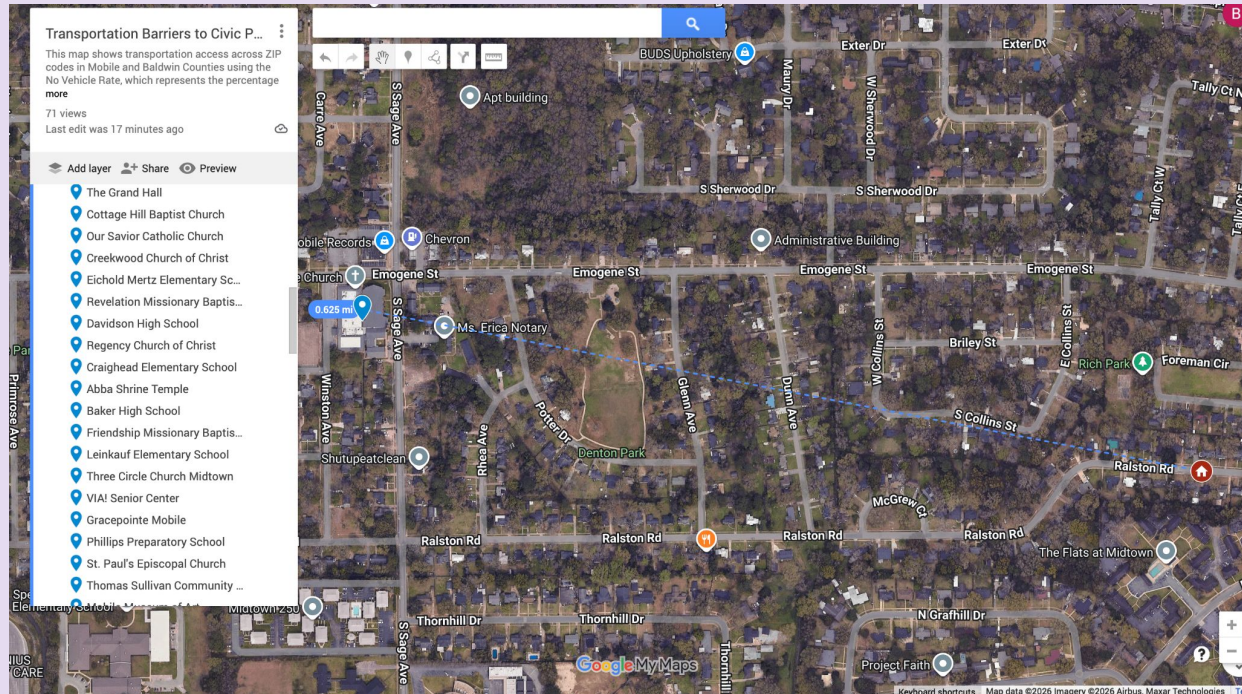
Red houses indicate higher transportation barriers, while **green houses** indicate lower barriers. **Blue markers** represent polling locations and show the relationship between transportation access and voting accessibility

Main Findings:

- ❑ Mobile County has more red ZIP codes suggesting higher transportation barriers in both urban and rural communities such as Mobile, Citronelle and Wilmer
- ❑ Baldwin County is mostly green, with areas like Daphne, Fairhope, and Gulf Shores showing better transportation access
- ❑ Some high barrier ZIP codes appear farther from polling locations, which make voting more difficult for residents without reliable transportation

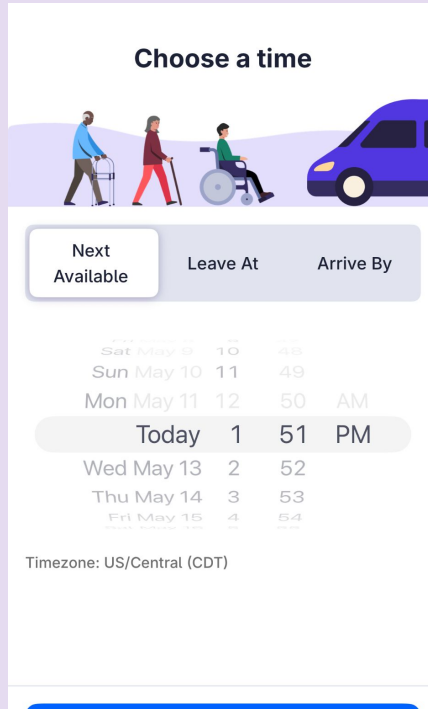
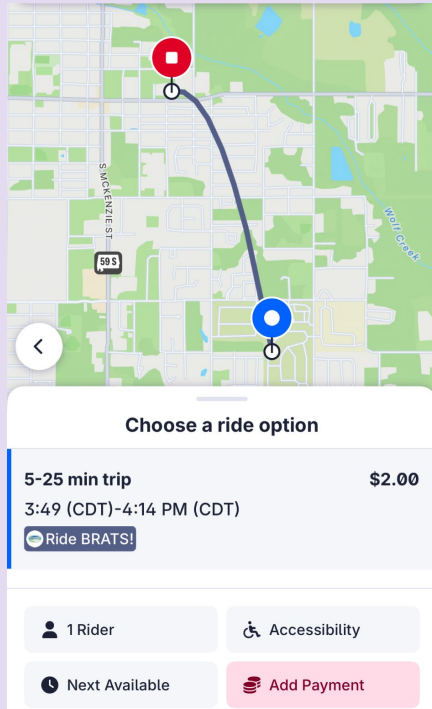
[Interactive Heat Map](#)

Transportation Access Across Zip Codes cont



- ❑ Dashed blue line represents estimated travel distance from ZIP code 36606 to Three Circle Church Midtown
- ❑ Estimated distance to polling location: 0.622 miles
- ❑ Short distances may still create barriers for residents without personal vehicles even within nearby communities
- ❑ Limited safe walking routes can reduce accessibility

Transportation System Differences Across Counties



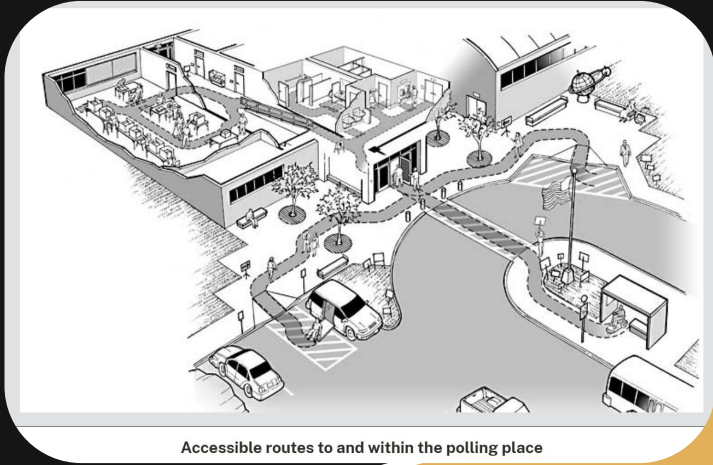
Baldwin County: On-Demand Model

- ❑ Primarily relies on **BRATS**, an on-demand rideshare service.
- ❑ Reduced costs: **\$2–\$5** depending on distance.
- ❑ Designed to improve transportation accessibility in rural areas.

Mobile County: Traditional Routes

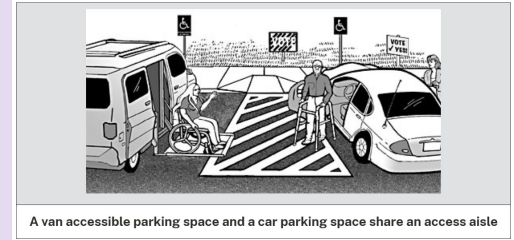
- ❑ Currently operates **fixed bus routes**.
- ❑ Ridership declines and rising costs have led to modernization talks.
- ❑ Considering transitioning to a rideshare model similar to Baldwin.

ADA Accessibility: Barriers at the Door



Accessible routes to and within the polling place

56% of 80 Mobile County polling locations reviewed had no visible evidence of accessible exterior parking features



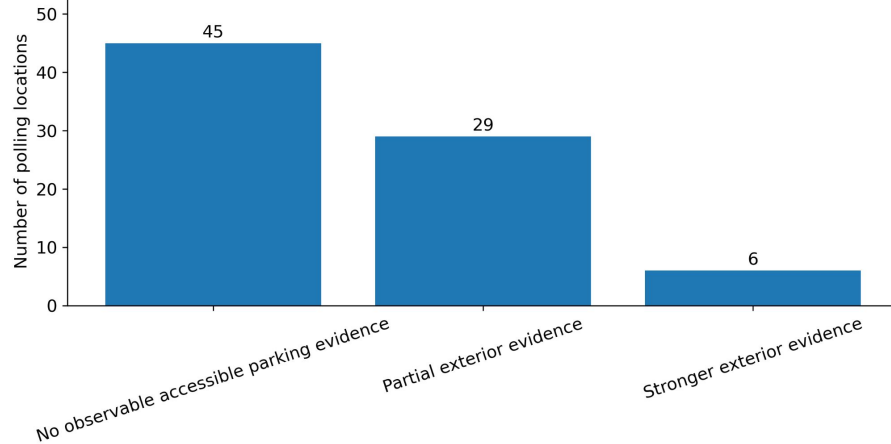
A van accessible parking space and a car parking space share an access aisle

8% showed strong exterior accessibility evidence across multiple checklist items



ADA Access and Accessibility Review Priority

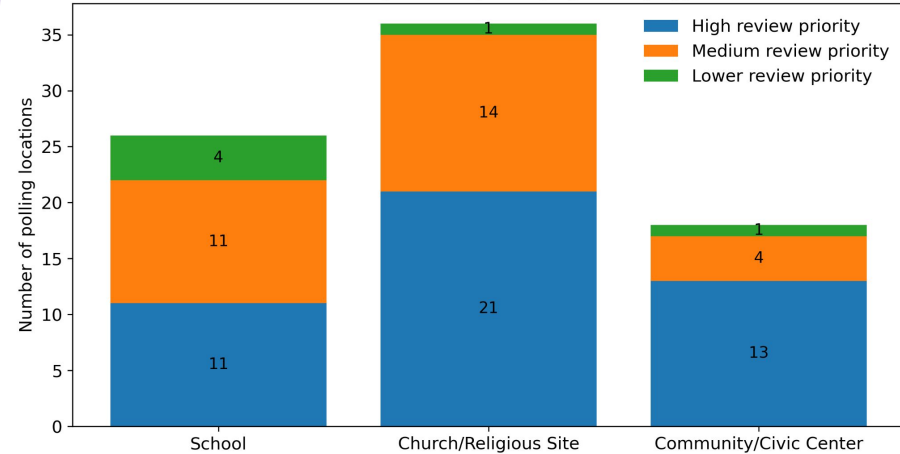
Mobile County polling locations by visible exterior ADA access evidence



Source: Team Google Earth review of Mobile County 2024 precinct checklist; DOJ ADA Polling Place Checklist criteria.

Shows the distribution of 80 Mobile County polling locations by visible exterior ADA access evidence, based on the team's Google Earth review and the 2024 Mobile County ADA Polling Locations Checklist

Accessibility review priority by facility type

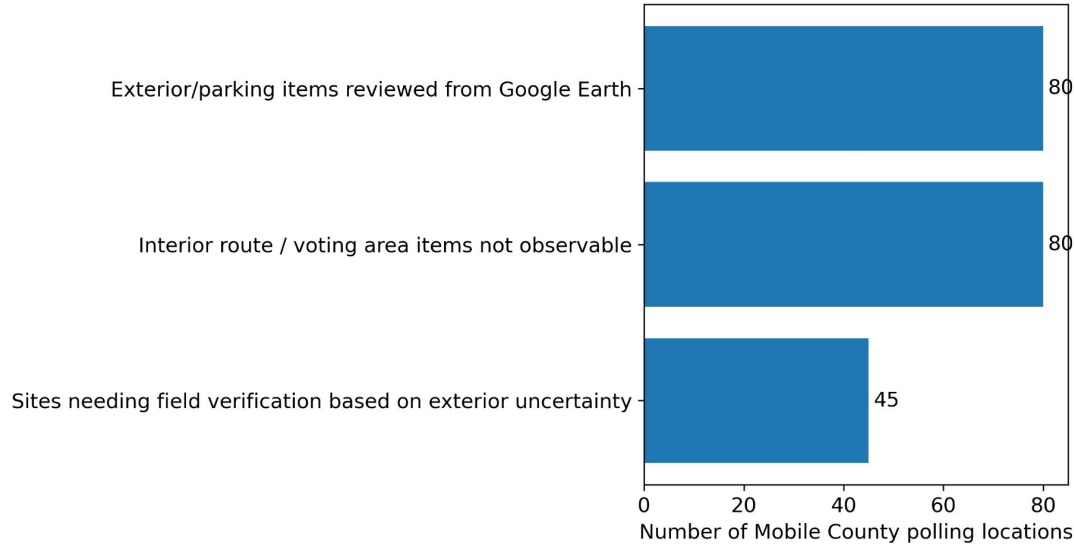


Source: Team Google Earth review; facility type inferred from precinct location names in the 2024 Mobile checklist.

Shows high, medium, and lower follow-up priority by inferred facility type, based on precinct names and visible exterior access evidence

Verification Checklist

What the checklist could and could not verify remotely



Source: Team review method using Google Earth imagery plus Mobile County 2024 checklist; DOJ checklist requires on-site measurement for many interior/route items.

Shows what the remote Google Earth method could verify and what still requires on-site measurement, based on checklist fields and DOJ polling place accessibility criteria

Parking

A	Parking - Only complete this section if off-street parking is provided to voters. If off-street parking is not provided to voters, go to Section B. If more than 25 parking spaces are provided to voters, see the 2010 Standards for the number of accessible parking spaces required. (§208.2)	Yes	No	N/A	Comments/Remedies
A1	Is there at least one designated van accessible space with signage with the International Symbol of Accessibility and designated "van accessible"? (§§208.2, 208.2.4, 502.6)				
A2	Are the designated van accessible spaces at least 96" wide with a 96" wide access aisle, or 132" wide with a 60" wide access aisle? (§§502.2, 502.3) Width of space _____ Width of access aisle _____				
A3	For van accessible spaces (particularly in a garage or parking structure), is there vertical clearance of at least 98" for the vehicular route to the parking space, in the parking space and access aisle, and along the vehicular route to the exit? (§502.5)				
A4	Are designated accessible parking spaces and the access aisles serving them on a level surface, with slopes not exceeding 1:48 in all directions? (Note: Curb ramps may not be part of an access aisle since they include slopes greater than 1:48.) (§502.4)				
A5	Are the surfaces of the designated accessible parking spaces and access aisles stable, firm, and slip resistant? (§§502.4, 302.1)				
A6	Are the designated accessible parking spaces located on the shortest accessible route to the accessible entrance? (§208.3.1)				39

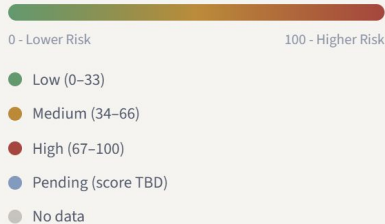
The Composite Picture

Every team built one piece of the puzzle

Team 7 put the pieces together

The Gulf Coast Composite Civic Participation Risk Index (CPRI)

Risk Score Legend



Scores are normalized 0–100 relative to all Alabama counties. Higher scores indicate a greater concentration of access-related risk factors.

The Gulf Coast Composite Civic Participation Risk Index (CPRI)

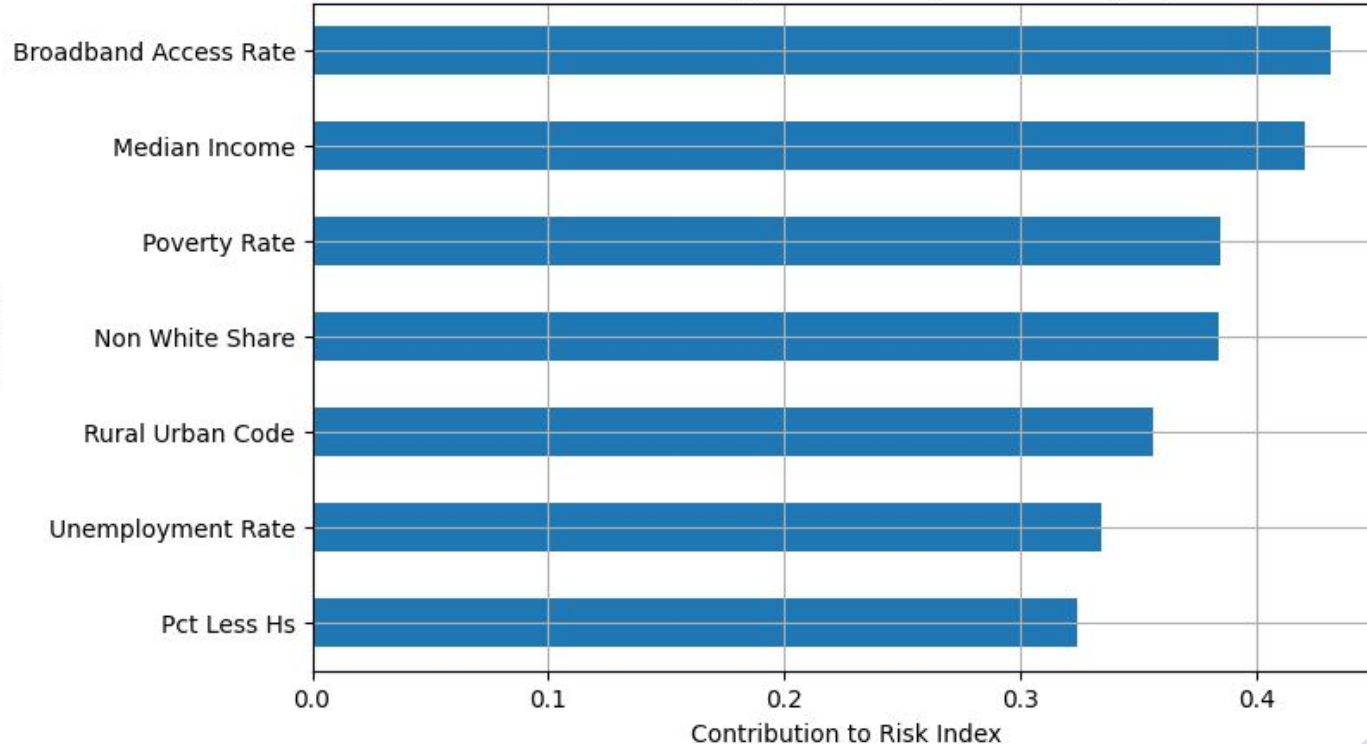
A county-level risk score combining socioeconomic, demographic, geographic, and infrastructure indicators—weighted by Principal Component Analysis (PCA) based on what actually explains variation across counties

PCA identifies underlying variance patterns across indicators and reduces dimensionality while preserving meaningful structure

GitHub Repository includes an [interactive web tool](#) that allows users to explore the final scores and adjust indicator weights to better understand how different factors influence county-level results

Core Indicators of Civic Participation Risk (PC1)

Variables Driving Civic Participation Risk (PC1)



Principal component 1 variable loading from the GC-CPRI PCA model, showing each select indicator's contributions to the first principal component and its contribution to the final county risk score

County Risk Scores

County Risk Scores

7 counties

SORT BY

Score ↓

Score ↑

A-Z

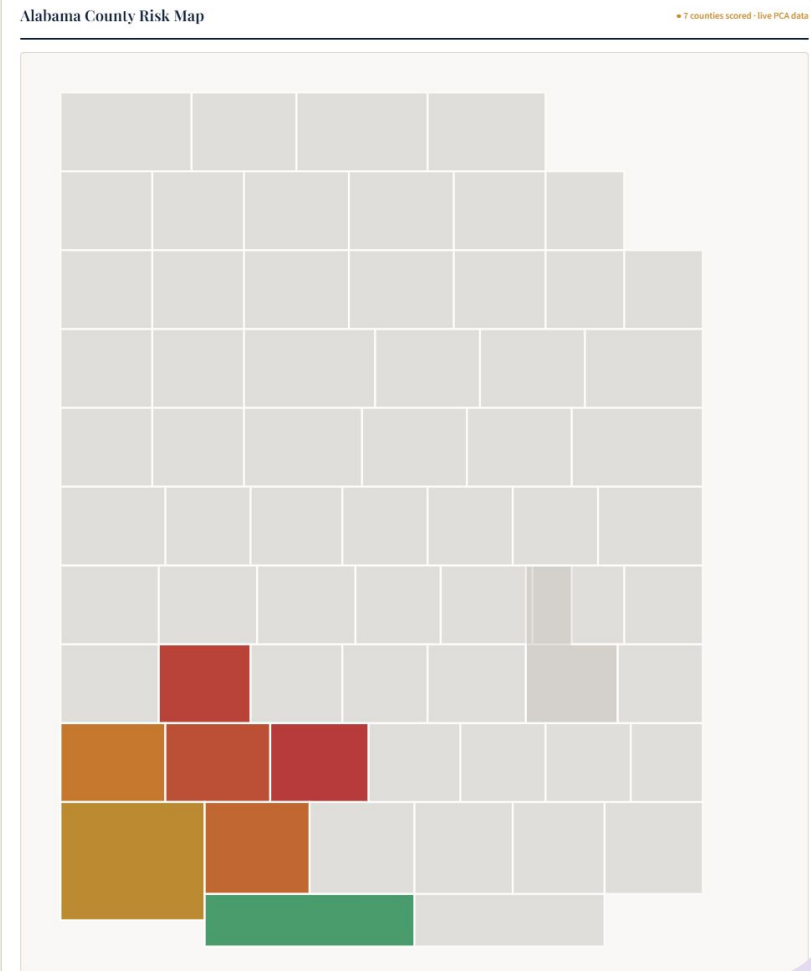
RANK	COUNTY	RISK SCORE	TIER	RELATIVE SCORE
1	Conecuh Alabama	100.0	HIGH	
2	Clarke Alabama	95.5	HIGH	
3	Monroe Alabama	86.6	HIGH	
4	Escambia Alabama	72.9	HIGH	
5	Washington Alabama	55.1	MEDIUM	
6	Mobile Alabama	42.6	MEDIUM	
7	Baldwin Alabama	0.0	LOW	

County risk scores displayed on the [interactive web app](#) based on the PCA model output and the selected socioeconomic, demographic, geographic, and infrastructure indicators

An analytical tool for comparing structural barriers to civic participation across Alabama's 7 Gulf Coast Region counties

Adjust indicator weights to explore how different factors shape the composite risk index

Select and compare counties



A Voter's Journey What This Looks Like for a Real Voter

Meet Mia

Mia Rodriguez

GC-CCP: Persona 2



Age: 62 **Gender:** Female
Race: Latina
Location: Baldwin County
Job: Unemployed

Goals

- Be a active US citizen
- Support her daughter's family

★ Immigrated in 2010

★ Citizenship in 2019

★ Lives with daughter's family

Voting habits

- Depends on daughter's family on transportation
- aware of voting in the US but unsure how to vote
- Relies on her daughter and church/communities for reliable information

Motivations

- Better schools for grandchildren
- Opportunities for older Latin generations to immigrate to the USA
- Improving the US naturalization process
- Trustworthy communication for community members

She is in her early 60s, originally from Mexico, and lives with her daughter's family in Baldwin County. When she immigrated from Mexico to the United States, she did not know much English, how the government worked, or what day to day life was like. Her days revolve around helping her daughter's family through cooking meals, picking up her grandkids from school, helping with homework, and providing stability at home. She attends Mass on the weekend at Foley Hispanic SDA Church and feels connected to the community through church. She wants to be an active citizen but finds sourcing information to be difficult. When it comes to voting, she won't participate unless she fully grasps what she is voting for.



STEP 1

Finding Out When and Where to Vote

Mia hears about the election at church, but the date and polling location are never confirmed.

Is it next week?
Where do I go?



Heard about it at church



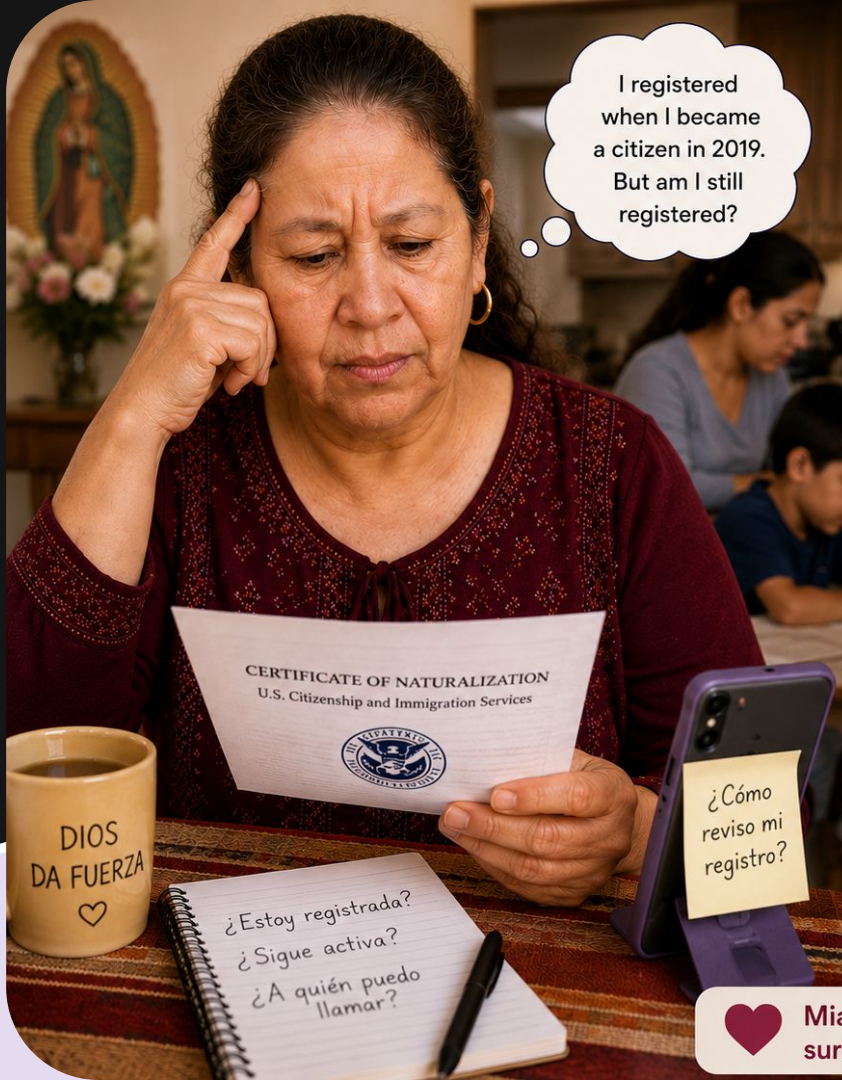
Shared device with limited access



Not sure of the date or polling location



Mia wants to vote, but getting reliable information is difficult.



STEP 2

Confirming Her Registration

Mia is not sure if she is still registered to vote. She can't check online, doesn't know who to call, and is afraid of being turned away at the polls.



BARRIERS

- No easy internet access
- Doesn't know voter assistance phone numbers
- Difficulty understanding phone systems in English
- Afraid of being rejected at the polls

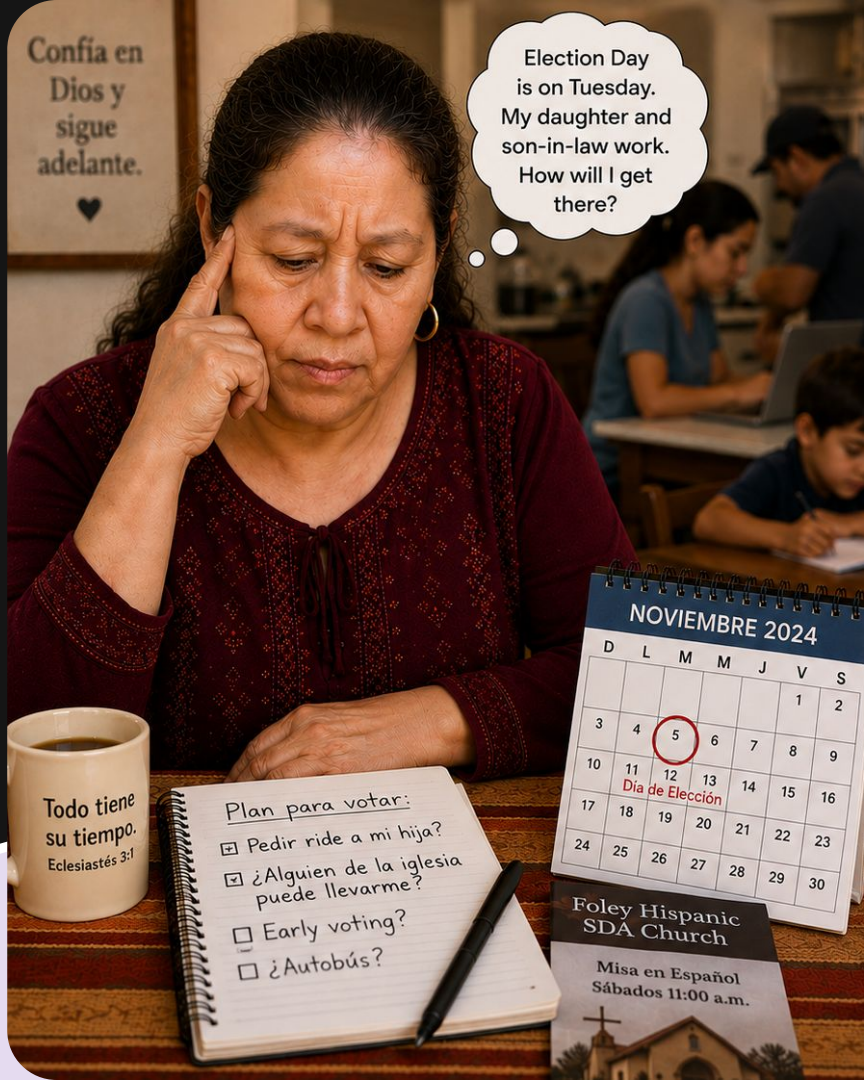


WHAT MIA NEEDS

- Human help in Spanish
- Paper confirmation of registration status
- Community-based voter help and hotlines



Mia wants to be prepared and make sure her vote counts.



Election Day
is on Tuesday.
My daughter and
son-in-law work.
How will I get
there?

STEP 3

Planning the Trip

Mia doesn't drive. Her daughter and son-in-law work during the day. Election Day is on a Tuesday, and she's not sure how she will get to the polling place.



BARRIERS

- No personal transportation
- Family members work and cannot take time off
- Limited public transportation options
- Church is on the weekend, not on Election Day
- Doesn't want to be a burden



WHAT MIA NEEDS

- Community rides or carpools
- Early voting or weekend voting options
- Clear information about transportation resources in Spanish
- Church-led voter support and ride coordination



Mia is determined to vote,
but needs help getting there.



STEP 4

Arriving at the Polls

Mia is not sure which building is her polling place. The address she found online may be outdated. When she arrives, the poll worker speaks only English. She brought her naturalization certificate — they ask for a photo ID instead.



BARRIERS

- Outdated or confusing polling place information
- English-only signage and communication
- Confusion about acceptable photo ID
- Limited bilingual poll workers or interpreters
- Embarrassment and stress in an unfamiliar environment

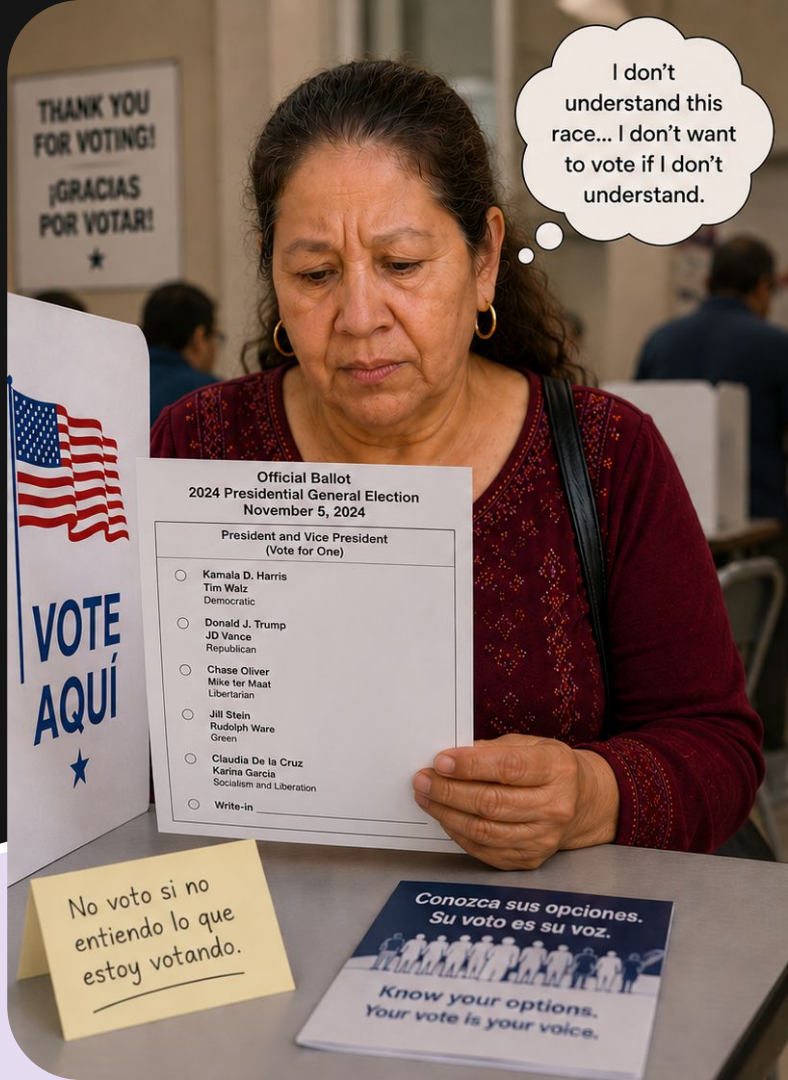


WHAT MIA NEEDS

- Accurate polling place information in Spanish
- Clear, simple ID requirements in Spanish
- Bilingual greeters or poll workers
- Welcoming, culturally responsive environment



Mia wants to vote and brought her important documents, but she feels nervous and unsure of what to do next.



STEP 5

Casting the Ballot

Mia receives a ballot in English only. She doesn't fully understand one of the races or the measure. She believes voting is a serious responsibility and does not want to guess. She decides to leave without casting a ballot.



BARRIERS

- English-only ballot and instructions
- Complex language and unfamiliar terms
- No Spanish sample ballot or voter guide
- Limited access to nonpartisan explanations of races and measures
- Strong belief: "I will not vote unless I fully understand what I am voting for."



WHAT MIA NEEDS

- Spanish-language sample ballots and clear explanations
- Plain-language guides for local races and ballot measures
- Community education and trusted, nonpartisan information
- More bilingual support at the polls



Mia wants to do the right thing. She just needs the information in a language she understands.

Today, she leaves without voting.

**Mia's story doesn't end there
She will face the same barriers
Next election
And the one after that...**

...unless

What We Built

A Common Visual Language

Before findings can inform decisions, they have to be understood

Team 8 developed a shared design standard, including color palette, typography, and visualization principles so that data about civic participation looks consistent whether it appears in a litigation brief, a policy summary, or a community guide



Typography

Bricolage

Grotesque/PT Serif

Weights: 700 (Bold) | Sizes: 57px

Site Usage: Key titles, hero sections, impact quotes on homepage

Visualization Use: Primary chart titles, large “Big Number” callouts, high impact headers

IBM Plex Sans/DM Sans

Weights: 700 | Size: 24px

Site Usage: Main menu text, subheadings, and utility navigation

Visualization Use: Secondary titles, axis labels, legend items, and button text

Crimson Pro/Jost

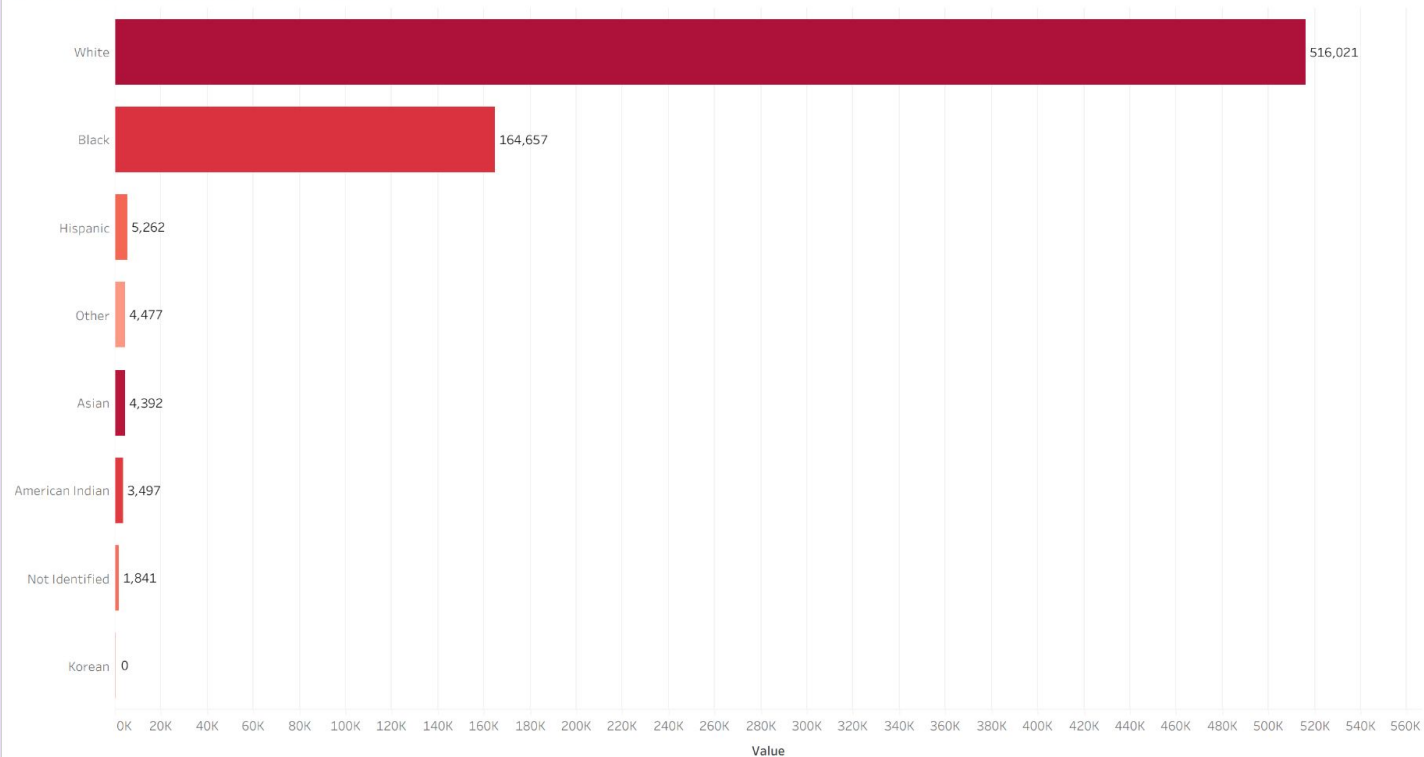
Weights: 400 | Size: 16px

Site Usage: Body copy, articles, descriptions

Visualization Use: Annotations, data sources, long form summaries or takeaways

Bar Chart - Before

Demographic Comparison by Ballots



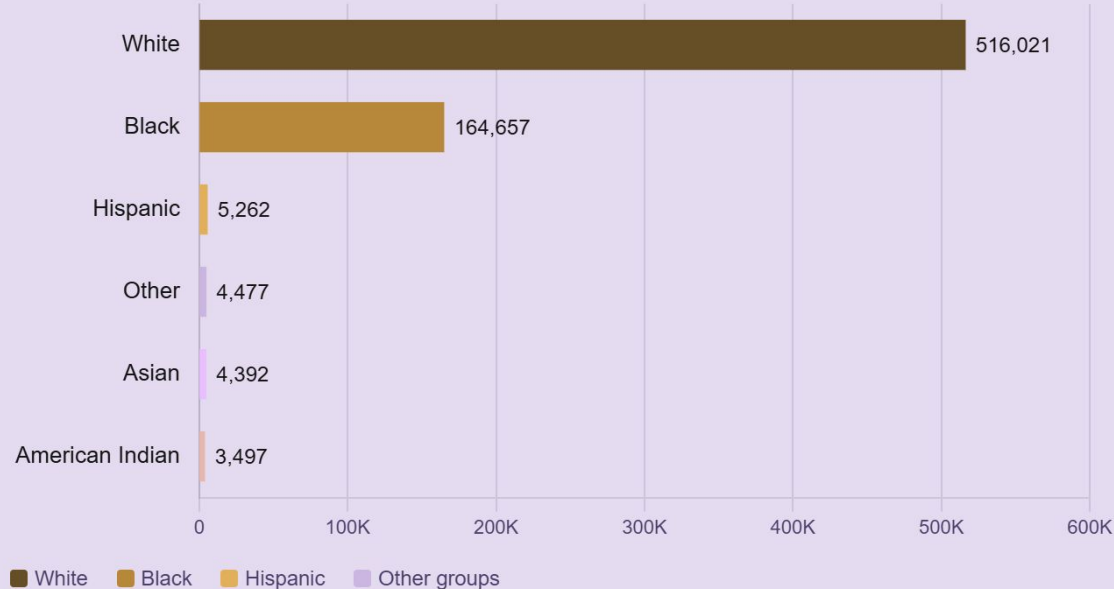
Bar Chart - After

Ballots Cast by Race

Alabama Gulf Coast region · General Election

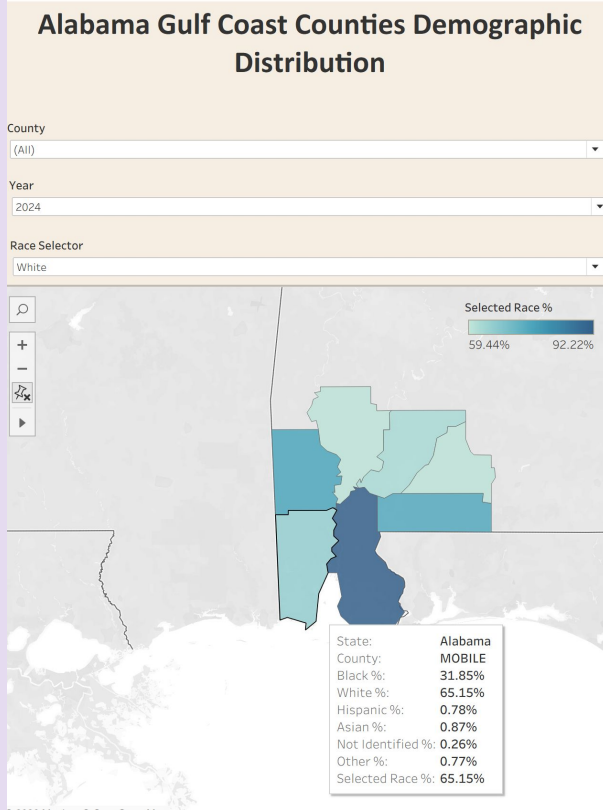
2024

2020

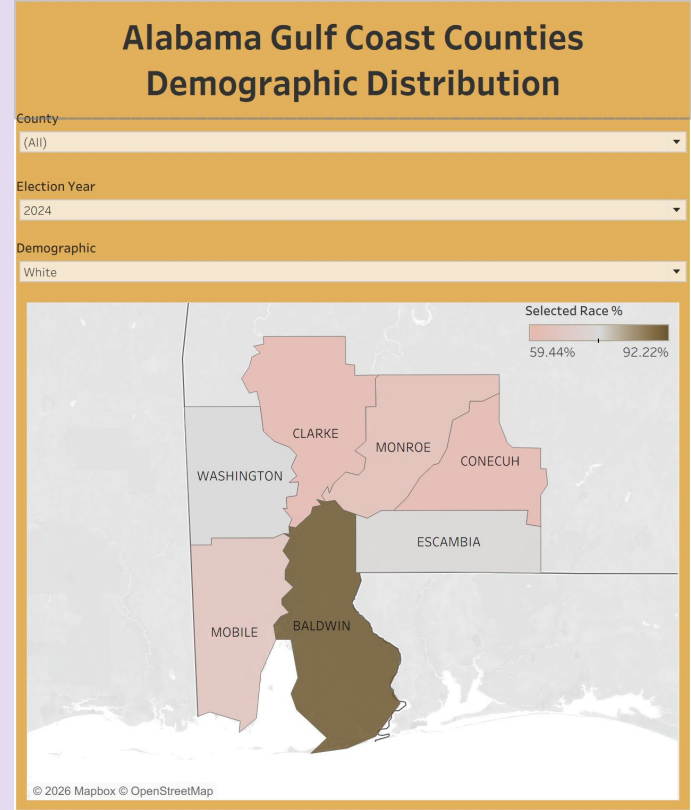


Source: L2 Voter File, via Redistricting Data Hub. Race reflects L2 modeled categories.

Voting Distribution Map

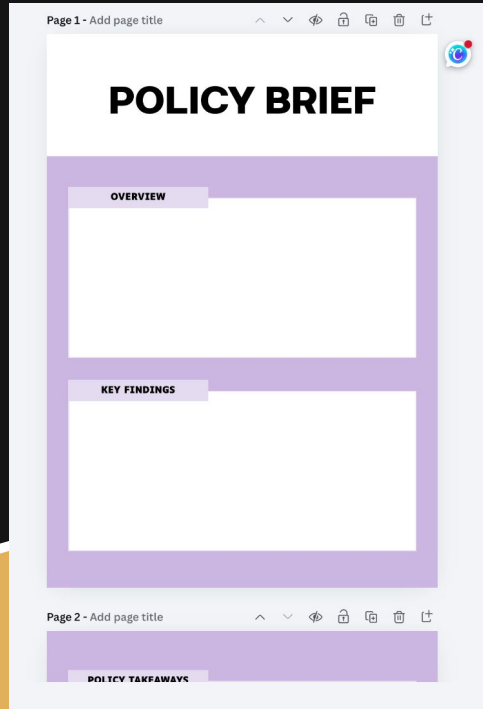


Before



After

Translating Data into Advocacy



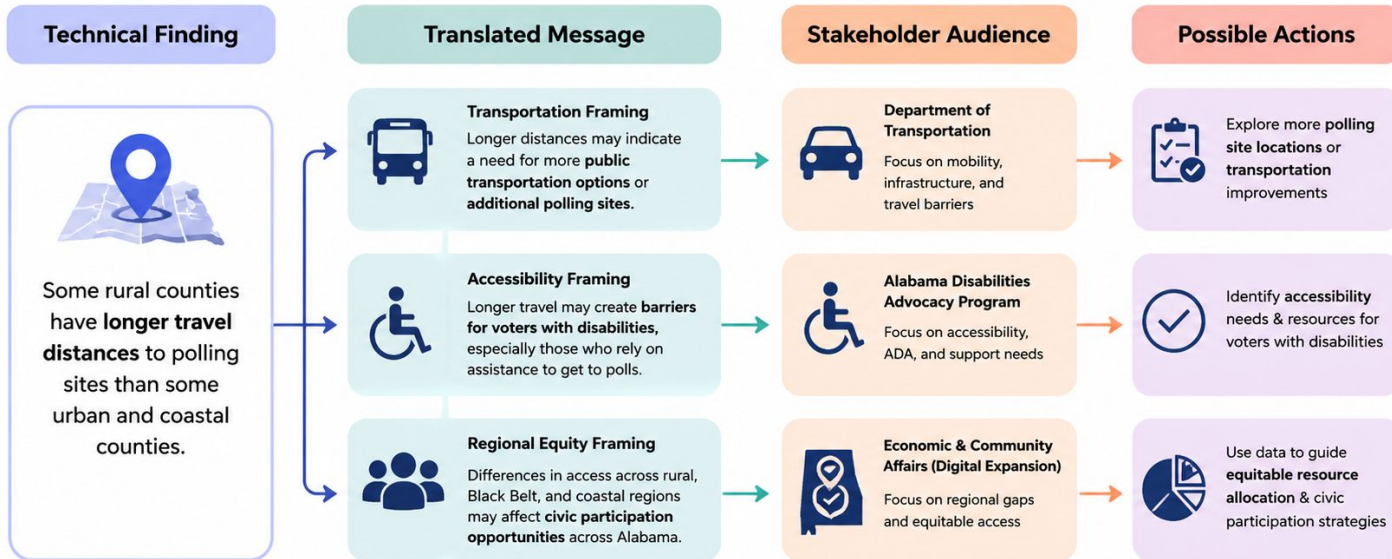
The same finding needs to be communicated differently depending on who has the power to act on it

Team 10 built a ***stakeholder communication framework*** and a ***reusable template*** for framing any finding in this presentation for any audience type

Policy Communication

From Data to Policy Action

How one technical finding is translated for different stakeholders



This framework shows how one technical finding can be framed for many different kinds of stakeholders

Policy Communication

Example: a state transportation director needs to hear which zip codes have the lowest vehicle access and the least transit coverage of polling locations

Other examples: a legislator needs the county-level evidence; a funder needs the gap, the intervention point, and the impact case

Transportation Analysis for Policy Use

OVERVIEW

This brief argues that transportation access should be treated as part of voting access in Mobile County. In-person voting depends not only on where polling places are located, but also on whether residents can realistically get there. Mobile County has more ZIP codes with higher no-vehicle household rates than Baldwin County, suggesting that some residents may face greater difficulty reaching polling locations. The purpose of this brief is to identify where transportation barriers may exist and show how transportation planning can better support civic access.

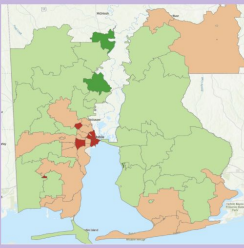


Figure 1.1: This heat map shows the level of transportation barriers based on the No Vehicle Rate and Barrier Score. Mobile County has more red ZIP codes, indicating higher no-vehicle household rates, while Baldwin County is mostly green, suggesting lower no-vehicle rates overall.

KEY FINDINGS

Transportation analysis shows that Mobile County has more ZIP codes with higher no-vehicle household rates than Baldwin County. This means more Mobile County residents may face difficulty reaching polling sites without access to a car. Specific areas of concern include parts of the city of Mobile and rural areas such as Citronelle and Wilmer. These areas may face different types of barriers. In urban areas, residents may live closer to polling places but be less likely to own a vehicle because of cost. In rural areas, residents may face longer distances, fewer transportation options, and greater dependence on private vehicles, public transportation, or rides from others. Because these barriers are not spread evenly, county-wide averages may hide ZIP codes with stronger access challenges. Drive-time analysis is helpful, but it does not fully measure access. A polling place may be a short drive away, but that does not help residents who do not own a car, cannot afford transportation, rely on limited transit, or cannot easily arrange a ride. Finally, inactive voter counts increased across Mobile and Baldwin Counties between 2020 and 2024. This does not prove transportation barriers caused voter inactivity, but it supports the need to examine transportation access alongside polling-place geography, registration barriers, public transit access, and household vehicle access.

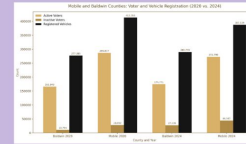


Figure 1.2: This graph shows that total voter registration increased in both Mobile and Baldwin Counties from 2020 to 2024. However, inactive voter counts also increased, especially in Mobile County. This shows that access barriers should be investigated further, but it should not be used to claim that transportation barriers directly caused voter inactivity.

Source: State of Alabama Department of Revenue Motor Vehicle Division Annual Reports for 2020 and 2024

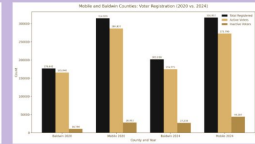


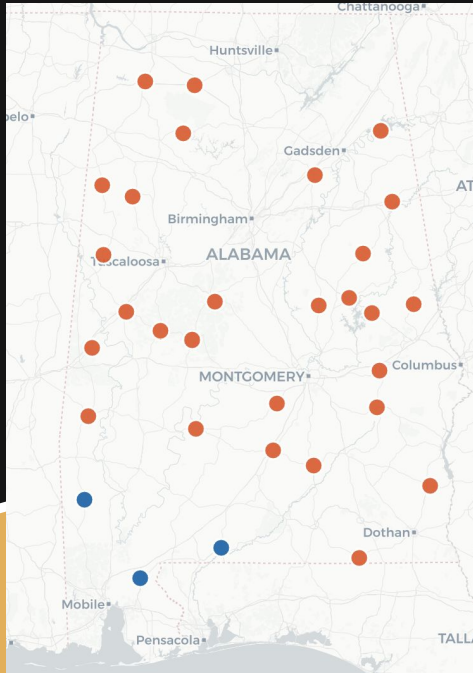
Figure 1.3: This graph compares active voters, inactive voters, and registered vehicles in Mobile and Baldwin Counties. It shows that Mobile County has many registered vehicles overall, but this does not mean every household has reliable access to a car. In the brief, this supports the point that county-wide vehicle totals can hide ZIP-code or neighborhood-level transportation gaps.

Source: State of Alabama Department of Revenue Motor Vehicle Division Annual Reports for 2020 and 2024

POLICY TAKEAWAYS

- **Treat polling locations as part of the transportation network.** Voting access should be considered alongside access to other public services, such as schools, healthcare, government offices, and community centers.
- **Prioritize areas with high no-vehicle household rates.** These communities may need targeted transportation support because residents may have fewer realistic options for reaching polling places.
- **Use ZIP-code and neighborhood-level data for planning.** County-wide averages can hide local transportation gaps, so smaller geographic analysis can better identify where support is most needed.
- **Coordinate transportation planning with election planning.** Polling-place decisions should consider nearby transit routes, on-demand ride services, road connectivity, pedestrian access, and travel burden.
- **Expand the definition of access beyond drive time.** Planning should account for whether residents can actually use the trip option available to them, not just how long the trip would take by car.
- **Develop targeted mobility supports for Election Day and early voting.** This could include partnerships with local transit providers, ride-assistance programs, shuttle options, or better public information about available transportation.
- **Use clear maps and visual tools to guide decisions.** Layering polling locations with no-vehicle rates, transit routes, and rural travel distances can help identify where transportation interventions would be most useful.

Getting Information to People Who Need It



Two documented decisions created access barriers for Black and Latine voters in Alabama:

- ❑ ***Shelby County v. Holder*** removed federal preclearance protections, allowing redistricting and ID requirements to take effect without federal review
- ❑ **31 driver's license offices were closed** in Alabama ahead of the 2016 election
 - ❑ Closures disproportionately impacted majority-Black counties in the Black Belt region
 - ❑ In the Gulf Coast region, Baldwin, Escambia, and Washington were also affected (*3 blue dots on the map*)

Team 11 responded with materials that help voters navigate the system as it currently exists

How To Vote in Alabama Gulf Coast : Journey Map



Potential Voter

Voters who live in the Alabama Gulf Coast (Mobile County and Baldwin County) may not be fully educated on the voting process in their state. This provides a detailed guide on the steps they would need to take if lost.

User Expectations

- Clear step-by-step guide for voters based on voting method
- Ability to compare voting methods to figure out what they want to use
- Offer straightforward voting information for target demographic

Gathering Information	Registration & Eligibility	In-Person Voting Process	Alternative Voting Process (Excused, Military, and Overseas Absentee Voting)
1. Figuring our Alabama election dates and deadlines 2. Checking Alabama state voting eligibility guidelines 3. Check out Alabama voter ID options 4. Learn more about Accommodations, Special Assistance and Contacts for Voters with Disabilities (if applicable) 5. Learn more about Alabama Voting rights Restoration (if applicable) 6. See Alabama Sample Ballot to be prepared for questions 7. Know your Election Office contacts for your county 8. Learn your voting options in Alabama 9. View your upcoming primary election dates	1. Confirm whether you are registered to vote in Alabama 2. Learn more about how to obtain a Voter ID if you don't already have one 3. Register to vote	1. Find your polling location 2. Learn if your state offers early voting (Alabama does not)	1. See if you are eligible for an Absentee Ballot 2. Learn how to submit a ballot request 3. Apply for your absentee ballot 4. Tracking your ballot status 5. Learn more about ballot return options Overseas and Military Voting (if applicable) : 6. Learn more about how to vote abroad as an overseas voter 7. Register to vote and request an absentee ballot abroad

OPPORTUNITIES

- Comparing voting methods so we can help Black and Latinx voters identify which voting option fits their specific circumstance and removes barriers to exercise their right to vote
- Breakdown each level of voting information so we can simplify the complex state and county-specific requirements into clear, accessible steps that meet each of our target communities where they are.

ACTIONS, MINDSETS, AND EMOTIONS

- Actions : I am taking steps to register to vote in my county in Alabama and learning what I need to know to confidently cast my ballot.
- Mindsets : I want to ensure my vote counts and I can get through the voting process safely, with limited issues arising.
- Emotions : I might feel overwhelmed by how much information I need to figure out but by the end, I will feel relieved and empowered knowing I successfully exercised my right to vote

Figure 1: "How to Vote Gulf Coast: Journey Map"
A figure to allow SPLC to see the experience of a Gulf Coast Alabama voter.

Voting Travel Plan

Ready to use or adapt
Formatted for Facebook and
Instagram distribution



Southern
Poverty
Law Center

WHERE TO VOTE

A Guide for Voters in ALABAMA



Find your assigned polling place and make a plan to vote.

STEP-BY-STEP: FIND YOUR POLLING PLACE

1



**CHECK YOUR
REGISTRATION**

Go to
myInfo.alabama.gov/voterview

2



**FIND YOUR
POLLING STATION**

Enter your name
and county to find
your assigned
polling location

3



**CONFIRM YOUR
PRECINCT**

You must vote at
THIS location only.
You cannot cross
precinct lines

4



**CHECK YOUR
BALLOT**

View your sample
ballot to see who
and what will be
on your ballot

5



MAKE A PLAN

Know how you
will get there
and when to go
Polls are open
7AM-7PM

WHAT TO BRING



VALID PHOTO ID

Driver's license, state ID,
or passport.



YOUR NAME AND ADDRESS

Make sure your information
is up to date.



ANY NEEDED DOCUMENTS

If you recently moved, be ready
to show proof of your new
address if required.

POSSIBLE BARRIERS PLAN AHEAD



TRANSPORTATION

Some polling places are far away. Plan
your ride early and allow extra time.



LONG LINES

Lines can be long, especially during
busy times. Go early or later in the
day if possible.



CONFUSION

If you are unsure about anything, ask a
poll worker. They are there to help.

Reaching the People the Data Describes

- ❑ Conecuh County's CPRI score of 100 highlights a high-priority geography, but geography alone does not determine effective engagement
- ❑ Actionable outreach depends on understanding community personas, communication channels, and trust networks
- ❑ Team 9's personas operationalize the analysis by linking findings to engagement tactics
- ❑ Clarifying SPLC's highest-priority persona will help focus outreach investments and deliverables

The People the Data Describes



Jay Hawk

22 · Mobile County

Job: Early employment

Info source: Parents

Barrier: Politics feel overwhelming — struggles to know who to trust

STRATEGY

Partner with HBCUs and young professional networks to deliver trusted, non-partisan voter information through people he already follows.



Mia Rodriguez

62 · Baldwin County

Job: Unemployed, lives with daughter's family

Info source: Church, daughter's family

Barrier: No transportation, limited English, won't vote unless she fully understands

STRATEGY

Distribute Spanish-language voter guides through Foley Hispanic SDA Church and coordinate Election Day rides through the same trusted community network.



Lauren Moore

48 · Mobile County

Job: Administrative assistant, healthcare

Info source: Mobile County website, Facebook

Barrier: Busy schedule — can't make time to vote or research candidates

STRATEGY

Reach her through the PTA and church networks she already leads — she is a trusted messenger. Equip her with shareable materials she can pass to others.



Johnson McBroom

35 · Conecuh County

Job: Unemployed, formerly incarcerated

Info source: Word of mouth, community orgs

Barrier: Doesn't know rights restoration process — paperwork feels insurmountable

STRATEGY

Partner with reentry organizations to provide plain-language rights restoration guides and one-on-one navigation support at community drop-in events.

Conclusions & Recommendations

Regional Summary

- ❑ Black turnout declined 6.6 percentage across all seven counties (2020–2024), while White turnout increased, consistently
- ❑ Escambia and Baldwin Counties show the largest gaps between eligibility and actual ballots cast for Black and Latine populations
- ❑ In Mobile County, distance alone is not the main spatial barrier, transportation access challenges persist
- ❑ 56% of polling locations in Mobile County cannot be verified as accessible based on available public imagery
- ❑ Only 2 of 7 counties have proper broadband coverage, limiting access to online civic participation tools across most of the region
- ❑ Composite Risk: Conecuh (100), Clarke (95.4), Monroe (86.5) are the highest-risk counties

What We Recommend

Prioritize the highest-risk counties

- ❑ Conecuh, Clarke, and Monroe show the most compounding barriers. These are where resources will have the greatest impact.

Treat transportation as a voting rights issue

- ❑ Low vehicle ownership plus thin transit coverage equals a documentable, geographic barrier that supports both litigation framing and Election Day advocacy.

Use community institutions as access points

- ❑ Libraries, churches, and social service organizations are trusted touchpoints where polling access is worst. Partner for outreach.

Connect broadband advocacy to voting rights work

- ❑ Online civic processes assume broadband. In most of this region, that assumption fails. The data makes this argument county by county.

Use the composite risk index as a prioritization tool

- ❑ Adjust indicator weights based on your current advocacy priorities and watch county rankings update in real time.

Next Steps

1.

Explore the risk index

<https://lacarabela.github.io/GC-CPRI/>—the starting point for county prioritization

2.

Identify your highest-priority use case

Litigation support, community outreach, policy advocacy — the answer shapes which deliverables to engage with first

3.

Final written reports and all deliverables

From all eleven teams to follow by May 19th

4.

Once shared, access the deliverables

All datasets, maps, dashboards, personas, briefs, and guides will be organized and accessible in the shared Google Drive folder

Team Credits

Project Team 1: Regional Voting Data Integration & Governance (GC-DIG)

- ❑ *Carter Kinch, Cidel Tetteh, Lin Han, Colin Sullivan, John Valencia*

Project Team 2: Voter Turnout & Participation Trends (GC-VOTE)

- ❑ *Afreen Ahmed, Nana Akuffo, Ryan Yu, Frank Okonsky, Nivitha Paranthaman, Manasvi Hosahalli*

Project Team 3: Polling Place Access & Distance Analysis (GC-PAD)

- ❑ *Casey Pham, Ana Salazar, Keon Marandy, Khadija Wane, Nhi Pham*

Project Team 4: Transportation Barriers to Civic Participation (GC-TRAC)

- ❑ *Andy Nguyen, Ayush Jain, Amisiyas Seyoum, Basirat Gbadegesin, Robert Tzou*

Project Team 5: ADA Accessibility & Compliance at Polling Locations (GC-AACS)

- ❑ *Sirisha Koirala, Sungjae Pae, Prince Osei, Elizabeth Jarvio-Barahona, Kediel Lam*

Project Team 6: Broadband & Digital Access for Civic Participation (GC-BAND)

- ❑ *Crystal Samoya, Asia Robillard-Hill, Lyndsey Bakal, Amir Pourmand, Garrett Bugg*

Project Team 7: Composite Civic Participation Risk Index (GC-CPRI)

- ❑ *Nathan Maldonado, Moiz Uddin, Akhil Ramesh, Talha Sohail, Elijah Lambros*

Project Team 8: Data Visualization & Dashboard Design (GC-VIZ)

- ❑ *Jin Peng, Alexander Peterson, Hana Hazem Elbarony, Mohammad Shahid, Noah Lehrfeld, Sera Belasco*

Project Team 9: Community Context & Personas (GC-CCP)

- ❑ *Bruktawit Mekonnen, Ryan Birmingham, Ayanna Sterling, Sue Chen, Ifa Bato*

Project Team 10: Policy & Organizational Translation (GC-PORT)

- ❑ *Sirak Abraham, Siddhi Kacholia, Margaret Nowell, Andrew Lu*

Project Team 11: Civic Participation Process & Access Design (GC-CPAD)

- ❑ *Janet Dabu, Mei Pierson, Ismail Touray, Daniel Chavez Celis*

Thank You!

We are happy to take any questions